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Guide has been adapted in the following languages Tok Pisin, عربي, Français, हिंदी, Bahasa Indonesia,
Português, Русский, Español, Kiswahili, 简体中文 from Familiarization, Internalization, Articulation
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2 Chronicles

2 Chronicles 1:1-6

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 1:1-6 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1-6 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1-6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Solomon, the son of King David, became the new king of Israel after David died. This story happens soon after David died.

Solomon made himself strong as king and took full control of the kingdom of Israel. King Solomon made himself strong by defeating his enemies to become the only ruler of Israel. King Solomon's older brother, Adonijah, had tried to become king, but Solomon told Solomon's military leader, Benaiah, to kill Adonijah. Solomon also told Benaiah to kill Joab and Shimei. Joab had been King David's military leader and had supported Adonijah when Adonijah rebelled. Shimei was from the tribe of King Saul and had cursed King David when David ran away from Absalom, because Shimei hated David and blamed David for the death of King Saul's sons. Solomon had also banished Abiathar the priest from the priesthood. These men had all been enemies of King David and were dangerous to Solomon now as king. Solomon also began to build a wall around Jerusalem and likely made sure the army stayed loyal to Solomon.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a person who became the leader of your community or country after that person struggled with other people who also wanted to become the leader. Describe all the things that the new leader did after he became the leader to make sure that he remained the leader and became strong. Pause this audio here.

Solomon became strong because Yahweh, Solomon's God, was with Solomon. Yahweh was the true king of Israel and had chosen Solomon to rule. Yahweh blessed Solomon, protected Solomon, and helped Solomon take full control of the kingdom. Yahweh made Solomon a great and powerful king. Yahweh also gave Solomon wealth and honor during Solomon's rule.

After Solomon took control of the kingdom of Israel, Solomon spoke to the people of Israel. King Solomon called all the people of Israel and their leaders together. It was normal for a king to gather the people for important events. The storyteller lists the leaders to show that all of Israel supported Solomon. Solomon spoke to the army commanders, the judges, and the leaders of Israel who were heads of clans, or groups of families and tribes. The army commanders who led the military of Israel were in charge of groups of 100 and 1,000 soldiers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss how you organize your warriors and the different levels of people who lead the warriors. Tell of a time when these leaders of the warriors had a disagreement with the great chief of your people. Pause this audio here.

The judges were also leaders in Israel because they were responsible for making sure people followed the rules. The judges did this by listening to the people's problems and deciding what was right according to the law of Israel. The heads of families were wise and important men from each clan or large family group.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss what your community's leadership structure looks like. For example, you may say that fathers lead their homes, clan leaders lead the clans, and the chiefs lead the community. Tell about a time when all these leaders, as well as the people, were gathered together. Pause this audio here.

We do not know what Solomon said in the gathering, but we know what happened next. Solomon and all the people went to the high place at Gibeon. High places were special places where people could worship, with altars for sacrifices. Before the Israelites built the temple, people used high places to worship Yahweh. People went to the high place at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting that Moses had made was there. Yahweh had told Moses that Yahweh would meet the people there and that the people should bring their sacrifices to the tent.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the Tent of Meeting. Talk about the place where the people of your community believe they can meet with God, the spirits, or the ancestors. Tell about a time that the leaders of your community went to that place, what they did, and why they did it. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that the ark of God was not in the Tent of Meeting at Gibeon. The ark was not there because King David had moved the ark from Kiriath Jearim to Jerusalem and placed it in a new tent. Normally, the ark stayed in the Tent of Meeting, but the Philistines had taken the ark of God during a battle. Later, the Philistines returned the ark, and then the people of Beth Shemesh took it and gave it to the people in Kiriath Jearim, where it stayed for 20 years. Then David brought the ark to Jerusalem. Even though the ark of God was not at Gibeon, the bronze altar was still there. This is the same altar that Yahweh had instructed Moses to make for burning sacrifices. Bezalel, the grandson of Hur, is the one who made this altar with the wisdom that Yahweh had given Bezalel.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the ark of God and the bronze altar. Pause this audio here.

Solomon and the people worshiped Yahweh at the bronze altar. Solomon offered 1,000 burnt offerings. The priests likely killed the animals, cut them up, and burned them completely, except for the skin, which they kept. These offerings showed that the people wanted to dedicate themselves fully to Yahweh. It is likely that the people dedicated their new king, Solomon, to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe the kind of offerings that the people of your community offer God, the spirits, or ancestors to please them. Tell of a time when a leader has offered a large number of sacrifices. Why did the leader do this?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1-6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: King Solomon took firm control of the kingdom of Israel because Yahweh was with Solomon. Yahweh made Solomon very great.

In the second scene: King Solomon spoke to all the people of Israel and to their military leaders, judges, and the heads of the families of Israel.

In the third scene: King Solomon and all the people who had gathered went to the high place at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting that Moses had made was there. The bronze altar that Bezalel, the son of Uri, had made was also there.

In the fourth scene: King Solomon and the people of Israel worshipped Yahweh there. And King Solomon offered 1,000 burnt offerings.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Solomon
- King David
- All the people of Israel
- The military commanders of thousands
- The military commanders of hundreds
- The judges of Israel
- The leading men of Israel who are heads of the families, or clans
- Moses
- Bezalel, the son of Uri and grandson of Hur
- And the priest who offered Solomon's sacrifices—the storyteller does not mention the priests, but they were likely there

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

King David had died, and David's son Solomon had become the new king of Israel. It is not clear how long after King David died this story takes place, but it is not too long. In the first scene, King Solomon strengthened himself over his kingdom, or took firm control of Israel. A king is normally the most powerful man in the kingdom. The king rules with the help of other powerful people, who can be dangerous to the king's rule if they are not loyal to the king. King Solomon strengthened himself over his kingdom by making sure that there was no one to challenge Solomon's rule. Solomon also strengthened himself over Israel by doing things that would make the Kingdom of Israel safe from its enemies. You will remember from the story in 1 Kings that Solomon built the wall of Jerusalem and made a marriage alliance with Pharaoh king of Egypt.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a leader who ruled your community or country strongly. Talk about how the leader was in control of everything. List the things that the leader did to make himself strong from the day he first became the leader. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use to describe the way the leader made himself strong and took full control. Pause this audio here.

Although Solomon made himself strong over Israel, Solomon was only able to do so because Yahweh, Solomon's God, was with Solomon. When a king was successful, the Israelites said that it was because Yahweh was with that king. Yahweh was the true king of Israel, and Yahweh chose which man would rule as Yahweh's representative. Yahweh had chosen Solomon, and therefore Yahweh protected Solomon and made him able to take control of the kingdom of Israel. Yahweh made Solomon very great. Yahweh had promised that Yahweh would make Solomon great. It is possible that the storyteller is referring to how Yahweh made Solomon great and gave him power and honor throughout Solomon's rule, not just at the beginning of Solomon's rule.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a person who was very successful. Tell about how God, the spirits, or ancestors protected that person, blessed him, and helped him succeed. What special language would you use to say that God, the spirits, or the ancestors made that person able to become successful? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, King Solomon spoke to all Israel. It is likely that King Solomon called a great gathering, or assembly, of all the people of Israel. It was common for kings to call for such gatherings at important times, especially at the beginning of the king's rule. The storyteller focuses on the levels of leaders who were there at the gathering. The storyteller likely does this to show that the people of Israel were united and loyal to King Solomon. King Solomon spoke to the leaders of Israel's military. Israel's army had fighting units made up of 1,000 soldiers each. Each unit of 1,000 soldiers had its leader. There were many of these units. Their leaders are the commanders of thousands. The military units of 1,000 were further broken down into units of 100 soldiers, each with its leader. These are the commanders of hundreds. King Solomon also spoke to the judges of Israel. The people often called rulers or leaders of Israel "judges." In this story, it is likely that the judges that King Solomon spoke to are the judges who decided which person was right or wrong when two people or groups had an argument. King Solomon also spoke to all the leading men of Israel who were heads of families. You will remember that there were 12 tribes in Israel, and each tribe was made up of clans or large family groups. From the days of Moses, the Israelites had tribal leaders as well as leaders of clans or large family groups.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Act out a scene where a military commander has harmed a person or their property. The person whom the commander harmed or his family should go to their clan leader and explain what happened and ask for justice. Their clan leader should then take them before a judge to ask for justice. Pay attention to the words and phrases that you use for military commander, clan leader, and judge. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, King Solomon and all the people who had gathered went to the high place that was at Gibeon. A high place usually refers to a dedicated place of worship set up on a high place, like a hill or mountain. But many of the high places of Israel were not on hills or mountains. It is better to think of a high place as a shrine or a sacred place of worship.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe a physical place that your community or another community you know goes to offer sacrifices. Talk about what the place looks like and how important it is. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use when you name this place. Make sure you choose a general name that you can also use to describe a similar worship place that belongs to another group of people. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon and the people went to the high place that was at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting for God was there. Gibeon was one of the cities of the Levites, in the territory of Benjamin. Gibeon was about 10 kilometers northwest of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map of the journey from Jerusalem to Gibeon. Pause this audio here.

This is the same tent that Moses, who served Yahweh faithfully, had made in the wilderness. Yahweh had asked Moses to make a temporary house that people made of skins. Yahweh said that Yahweh would speak with the people of Israel from the Tent of Meeting. The Israelites, therefore, called it the Tent of Meeting, the tabernacle, or the tent of Yahweh's presence. The storyteller adds a comment to explain to us that the ark of God was not in the Tent of Meeting like it was when the Israelites first made the tent. Earlier, King David had taken the ark from Kiriath Jearim to Jerusalem and put it in another tent at the place King David had prepared for it.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have someone tell a story. As the person is telling the story, he should pause the story to explain or add some information about what he has been saying. For example, the person could be speaking of the story of a great harvest that your community has enjoyed and then pause the story to make a comment about someone who did not plant anything at planting time. Pause this audio here.

But the bronze altar that Bezalel, the son of Uri and grandson of Hur, had made was there standing in front of the Tent of Meeting. Bezalel had made this altar by mixing two metals, copper and tin, to make a metal called bronze. The altar was standing before the Tent of Meeting because that is what Yahweh had commanded. Sometimes the word tabernacle refers to the entire Tent of Meeting, including the fence around it. In this case, it refers only to the two rooms in the main tent, the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of the entire Tent of Meeting with the bronze altar standing before the Tent of Meeting. Pause audio here.

In the fourth scene, King Solomon and the people with him worshipped or asked Yahweh for advice there. It is possible that the storyteller means that Solomon and the people went to sacrifice at Gibeon often. King Solomon went up to the bronze altar in front of Yahweh's Tent of Meeting and offered 1,000 burnt offerings on the altar. It is unlikely that Solomon himself made the offerings. Normally, priests would kill, cut up, and burn the entire animal on the altar, apart from its skin. It is likely that Solomon offered the burnt offerings to dedicate himself and his rule over Israel to Yahweh.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1-6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Solomon
- King David
- All the people of Israel
- The military commanders of thousands
- The military commanders of hundreds
- The judges of Israel
- The leading men of Israel who are heads of the families, or clans
- Moses
- Bezalel, the son of Uri and grandson of Hur
- And the priest who offered Solomon's sacrifices—the storyteller does not mention the priests, but they were likely there

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

King Solomon took firm control of the kingdom of Israel because Yahweh was with Solomon. Yahweh made Solomon very great.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy and blessed. Yahweh is giving me control of Israel; or
- I am aware and alert for danger within Israel as well as from outside; or
- I am determined to secure myself as king.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel pleased with Solomon; or
- I am happy to give Solomon the power to defeat his enemies; or
- I feel loved by my obedient son Solomon. I will give Solomon favor and success.

Continue the drama.

King Solomon spoke to all the people of Israel and to their military leaders, judges, and the heads of the families of Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel excited. This is a special day for Israel; or
- I am happy to honor Yahweh with all Israel; or
- I feel very happy to see the loyalty and unity my people have.

Ask the person playing the commanders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel honored by our king; or
- We love King Solomon, and we will serve Solomon loyally; or

- We are encouraged by our young king's wisdom. Solomon has done a very good job so far.

Ask the person playing judges and heads of families, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are very pleased with the purpose of this gathering. When Solomon's father became king, David called all the leaders of Israel, and they went and brought the ark of Yahweh. King Solomon wants us to worship Yahweh at Gibeon and ask for Yahweh's help; or
- We are proud of our young king's wisdom and success; or
- We feel great hope for the future of our people and nation.

Continue the drama.

King Solomon and all the people who had gathered went to the high place at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting that Moses had made was there. The bronze altar that Bezalel, the son of Uri, had made was also there. But King David had brought the ark of God to Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel like rejoicing and celebrating; or
- We feel awe and amazement. We are at the tent of Yahweh's presence. We hope and pray that Solomon will serve Yahweh as faithfully as Moses did; or
- We feel excited to see the work Yahweh is doing in Israel today. Yahweh has given Solomon wisdom to rule just as Yahweh gave Bezalel wisdom to make the bronze altar.

Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel humbled to be in this holy place; or
- I feel sad that the ark was separated from the Tent of Meeting and that the people still have not got a permanent place to worship Yahweh; or
- I am determined to do the work Yahweh has given me. I will build the temple.

Continue the drama.

King Solomon and the people of Israel worshipped Yahweh there. And King Solomon offered 1,000 burnt offerings.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the heads of families, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel a great desire that Yahweh would guide our king; or
- We feel blessed to have a king like this who leads the whole nation to worship Yahweh.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am honored by my people; or
- I am pleased by the sweet smell of the burnt sacrifices; or
- I have heard and will answer Solomon.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1-6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Solomon, the son of David, established himself in his kingdom, and Yahweh, Solomon's God, was with Solomon. A kingdom is the territory or the people that a king rules. Yahweh is a name that God gives himself. This name means something like "I am," or "I am who I am." God is a less personal or more general name that people sometimes used to refer to Yahweh. This is the God who created everything, the most powerful spiritual being.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **kingdom, Yahweh, and God**. Look up kingdom, Yahweh, and God in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon spoke to all Israel, to the commanders, judges, leaders, and heads of families. Israel is the land that Yahweh promised to Abraham and his descendants. At some point, the people of Israel fought among themselves and divided the land into two kingdoms. At this point, Israel refers to the whole kingdom before it was divided. A commander is the military officer who is in charge of other soldiers. Israel's military commanders were in charge of either 1,000 or 100 soldiers. A judge is a person who judges actions that people do and decides if what those people have done is right or wrong, and therefore if a person is guilty or innocent of breaking a law. A judge will punish the person if the judge decides that the person is guilty of doing wrong. The leaders were the chiefs or leading men in all Israel. The heads of families were specifically the chiefs or the most important men from each clan, or large family group, in Israel. It is likely that leaders and heads of families refer to the same group of men.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Israel, commanders, judges, leaders, and heads**. Look up Israel and judges in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon and all the assembly went to the high place at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting that Moses, the faithful or loyal servant of Yahweh, had made in the wilderness was there. "All the assembly" refers to all the people who had gathered together for a common purpose. Because Yahweh chose the people of Israel, people usually call gatherings of the people of Israel the "assembly" of Yahweh. The Tent of Meeting is another name for the tabernacle. This is where the Israelites worshipped Yahweh. The people called it the Tent of Meeting because it was where the Israelites could meet Yahweh. A servant is a person who does work for someone else. People sometimes call someone who worships and obeys Yahweh a servant of Yahweh. A wilderness is a lonely, barren place without water. There are almost no trees or bushes growing in a wilderness. The ground is dry and rocky, and there are wild animals roaming around. People do not live in the wilderness.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **assembly, Tent of Meeting, servant, and wilderness**. Look up **tabernacle**, servant, and wilderness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

But David had brought the ark of God to Jerusalem. The bronze altar that Bezalel, the son of Uri, had made was also there in front of the tabernacle. The ark of God is the oblong box that people made of acacia wood that Yahweh asked Moses to make. Sometimes people call this box the ark of the covenant. Yahweh spoke to Moses from above the ark. Bronze is a metal that people made by combining copper and tin. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God. The people of Israel burned their animal sacrifices on the bronze altar. The tabernacle was a portable temple that the Israelites carried with them during their years of traveling in the wilderness. This was the place where the Israelites kept the ark of the covenant and where the people worshiped God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **ark, bronze, altar, and tabernacle**. Look up **ark of the covenant**, bronze, and altar in the Master Glossary for more information. Remember that the storyteller calls the ark the "ark of God" in this story. Remember that "tabernacle" is another way to say the Tent of Meeting. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon offered 1,000 burnt offerings on the bronze altar. A burnt offering is a form of sacrifice that people bring to Yahweh. When a person brings Yahweh a burnt offering, he kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar. The people brought Yahweh burnt offerings as a way to completely dedicate themselves to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **burnt offering**. Look up burnt offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 1:7-13

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 1:7-13 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7-13 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7-13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, Solomon became the king of Israel after his father, David, died. Solomon gathered together the people of Israel and their leaders and went to make offerings to Yahweh at the bronze altar that was at the high place in Gibeon.

This story happened on the night of that same day that Solomon offered the burnt offerings to Yahweh. Solomon was still at the high place in Gibeon. That night, Yahweh appeared to Solomon. Yahweh told Solomon to ask Yahweh for anything that Solomon wanted. The storyteller does not tell us how Yahweh appeared to Solomon. The storyteller does say that it was at night. Solomon would have been asleep and dreaming. Yahweh sometimes appears to people in their dreams.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell stories of people in your community who received messages from God, the spirits, or the ancestors while they were dreaming. What messages did those people receive? Pause this audio here.

Solomon told Yahweh that Yahweh had already shown great kindness to Solomon's father, David, and that Yahweh had continued to be kind by making Solomon king after David. Yahweh had promised David that Yahweh would bless David and make some of David's descendants kings of Israel. Solomon told Yahweh that Yahweh had fulfilled Yahweh's word, or promise to David, because Yahweh had made Solomon king of the people of Israel. It is also possible that Solomon was actually asking Yahweh to fulfill Yahweh's promise rather than saying that Yahweh had already fulfilled it.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In the previous discussion, you talked about people who had received a message from God, the spirits, or the ancestors in a dream. Now discuss whether those messages were about true things that actually happened or not. Pause this audio here.

Solomon said that the people of Israel were as many as the dust of the earth or the grains of dust. Yahweh had promised Jacob, the ancestor of the 12 tribes of Israel, that the people of Israel would become as many as the dust of the earth. Solomon is saying that he has very many people to rule over.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect some sand or dust in your hand and try to count the grains one by one. Pause audio here.

Solomon then asked Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom and knowledge to go out and to come in before the people of Israel. In Israel, because the leaders led the warriors out when they went to war and led the warriors back home after the war, to go out and to come in became another way to talk about leading people. Solomon is asking Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom or the ability to make good decisions that would make Yahweh happy. Solomon also asks for knowledge. Solomon wants to understand things about Yahweh, to know right from wrong, and to learn important truths. Knowledge is a special gift from Yahweh, but also something people try to learn. When people have knowledge, those people have the ability to make wise decisions. Knowledge is just the first step to becoming wise. Solomon is asking Yahweh to help Solomon think clearly so Solomon can be a good king and make smart, helpful choices. It is likely that when Solomon prays for wisdom, Solomon is also asking for the skills to build the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss the different ways in which a king or great chief leads his people. For example, how does a king lead in war, in building projects, in legal cases, or religiously? What skills or characteristics does a leader need to be successful in all these areas of leadership? Pause this audio here.

Solomon told Yahweh that Solomon asked for wisdom and knowledge because no one would be able to judge or rule the many and important people of Yahweh.

Yahweh was pleased that Solomon did not ask for possessions, riches, honor, or even for Yahweh to kill Solomon's enemies or to give Solomon a long life. Yahweh said that Solomon's heart desire was wisdom and knowledge to rule the people of Yahweh. The people of Israel believed that a person's heart controls that person's thinking, choices, and ability to know right from wrong. The heart's desire is the thing that someone really wants.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Which part of the body does your community believe our desires come from? Pause audio here.

Yahweh said that because of this, Yahweh would give Solomon the thing that Solomon had asked for—wisdom and knowledge. Yahweh said that Yahweh would also give Solomon the things that Solomon had not asked for—possessions, riches, and honor. Yahweh also said that Yahweh would give Solomon these things more than any king that had come before Solomon or any that would come after Solomon. It is not clear whether Yahweh meant that Yahweh would give Solomon more of these things than any of the kings of Israel or more than Yahweh would give the kings of all the nations.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the wisest, richest, and most respected king or leader that your community has ever had. Give examples of that person's wisdom, riches, and the respect people gave him. Where did the king or leader get these things from? Pause audio here.

Then Solomon left the Tent of Meeting that was at Gibeon, where he had gone to offer burnt offerings to Yahweh, and went back to Jerusalem. It is likely that Solomon went back to Jerusalem in the morning after the night Solomon had the dream.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the Tent of Meeting and a map of the journey from Gibeon to Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Solomon ruled over Israel from Jerusalem.

This story is important because it shows the people of Israel that King Solomon cared more about being a good king and doing what Yahweh wanted than about being rich and powerful.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7-13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: Yahweh appeared to Solomon at night and told Solomon that Yahweh would give Solomon anything that Solomon asked for. Solomon asked Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom and knowledge to rule Yahweh's great people, Israel. And Yahweh said that Yahweh would give Solomon wisdom and knowledge and more possessions, riches, and honor than any other king before or after Solomon.

In the second scene: Solomon left Gibeon and the Tent of Meeting that was there and went back to Jerusalem. Solomon ruled Israel.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Solomon
- King David
- The people of Israel
- And the other kings that came before and after Solomon

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, God appears to Solomon. You will remember that in the last story, Solomon offered burnt offerings to Yahweh. In this story, Solomon is still at the high place in Gibeon, but it is now nighttime. Solomon is asleep and dreaming. God appears to Solomon and tells Solomon that God will give Solomon anything that Solomon asks for. God sometimes spoke to people in dreams.

Solomon answered Yahweh. Solomon began by reminding Yahweh how Yahweh had treated Solomon's father, David. Solomon said that Yahweh had shown great kindness to Solomon's father, David, and continued to be kind by making Solomon king after his father, David. Solomon is saying that Yahweh had shown steadfast love and was loyal to David because Yahweh had made a promise and agreement with David. Yahweh had promised David that David's family would rule Israel, and now Solomon, David's son, was king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about someone that God, the spirits, or ancestors loved and protected. Describe how God, the spirits, or the ancestors remained loyal to that person and never left the person. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use to describe this kind of love. Pause this audio here.

Solomon talks about how Solomon wants Yahweh to treat Solomon. The scene begins with a word that shows that Solomon is not talking about the past anymore. Solomon asks Yahweh God to fulfill his word because it is Yahweh who had made Solomon king of Israel. Yahweh's word is the promise that Yahweh had made to David. It is also possible that Solomon is saying that Yahweh had already fulfilled the word or promise that Yahweh had made to David because Solomon has become king. Solomon said the people of Israel were as many as the dust of the earth.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the largest group of people you have ever seen in your life. What special language can you use to say how many people they were? Use words or phrases that describe a number of people too many to count. Pause this audio here.

Solomon asked Yahweh for wisdom and knowledge to go out and come in before the people of Israel. The leaders of Israel went out before the people when going to war and came in before the people when returning from war. For this reason, people used the phrase “to go out and to come in” as a special way of saying to lead people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell stories of the greatest leader that your community or country has ever had. Discuss and describe the different ways he led your people. How do you talk about the way this person led the people? How will you say that Solomon asked Yahweh for wisdom and knowledge to go out and to come in before the people of Israel? Pause this audio here.

Solomon wanted wisdom and knowledge so he could lead well. A person who has wisdom is able to make good decisions that lead to good results. People who have certain skills, like the ability to build or to make something beautiful, are also wise. It is Yahweh who gives wisdom to people. When a person has knowledge, that person has a good understanding of things. People gain knowledge by learning information or skills.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about someone in your community who learned something that they did not know and continued learning for many years so that they became the most experienced or wisest person in that subject. For example, you may want to talk about someone who learned something like ruling or hunting. Pay attention to the words and phrases that you use to describe the knowledge this person learned and the wisdom they had after many years. Pause this audio here.

Solomon asked Yahweh a question to make a statement. Solomon said that no one could judge or rule Yahweh’s great people. Solomon is saying that if Yahweh does not help Solomon, Solomon will not be able to be a good king. Solomon calls Israel Yahweh’s great people. Solomon meant two things when he called Yahweh’s people great. Firstly, Yahweh was the true king of Israel, and therefore the people of Israel were Yahweh’s people, or very important people. Secondly, the people of Israel were very many.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about how you will refer to Yahweh’s great people. Remember that they are great because they are important as well as many. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh was happy because Solomon had not asked for possession, riches, honor or respect, long life, or for Solomon’s enemies to die. Yahweh was happy because the desire of Solomon’s heart was wisdom and knowledge to rule well. In Israel, people believed the heart helped you think, choose, and know right from wrong.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about something you really want. Explain why you want it so much. How do you describe the feeling you have of wanting something so much? How will you talk about the desires of Solomon’s heart? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh said Yahweh would give Solomon the wisdom and knowledge that Solomon had asked for. Yahweh also said Yahweh would give Solomon the things Solomon had not asked for. Yahweh said that Yahweh would give Solomon more wisdom, knowledge, possessions, riches, and honor than any king before or after Solomon. It is not clear if Yahweh meant only the kings of Israel or all kings. Yahweh does not say that Yahweh would give Solomon a long life or kill Solomon’s enemies. Solomon had already killed some of Solomon’s enemies.

In the second scene, Solomon left the Tent of Meeting in Gibeon and went back to Jerusalem. Solomon likely returned in the morning after the dream. Solomon had gone to Gibeon with the people of Israel and their leaders, but the storyteller does not mention those people here. Solomon ruled Israel from Jerusalem. Gibeon was one of the cities of the Levites, in the territory of Benjamin. It was about 10 kilometers northwest of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map of the journey from Jerusalem to Gibeon. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7-13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Solomon
- King David
- The people of Israel
- And the other kings that came before and after Solomon

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, Yahweh appeared to Solomon at night and told Solomon that Yahweh would give Solomon anything that Solomon asked for.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel honored by Solomon; or
- I am pleased with Solomon’s burnt offerings and his dedication to me; or
- I love Solomon as I loved his father, David. I want to know if Solomon will be faithful to me as David was.

Ask the person playing Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am amazed by Yahweh; or
- I feel very afraid of Yahweh’s glory; or
- I feel so happy. Yahweh has answered my prayers.

Continue the drama.

Solomon answered Yahweh and said that Yahweh had shown Solomon’s father, David, great kindness.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel great joy. My heart is full of praise for Yahweh. Yahweh’s word is true, and Yahweh keeps his promises; or
- Yahweh is a faithful God. Yahweh kept his word to David, and I desire the same love and loyalty Yahweh gave my father; or
- I love Yahweh. I feel that Yahweh loves me for the sake of my father, David.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel honored; or
- I love to keep my promises, and I love those who recognize my faithfulness; or
- I am happy that Solomon knows I am the one who made Solomon king of Israel.

Continue the drama.

Solomon asked Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom and knowledge to rule Yahweh’s great people, Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel overwhelmed by my job as the king of Yahweh’s many important people; or
- I am scared that I will fail and make Yahweh angry; or
- I feel desperate for Yahweh’s help.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that Solomon has not been selfish and asked for things for himself, but has asked for what Solomon needs to rule My people well; or
- Solomon wants what I also want and this makes me very pleased with Solomon; or
- I love how Solomon loves me and loves people.

Continue the drama.

Yahweh said that Yahweh would give Solomon wisdom and knowledge and more possessions, riches, and honor than any other king before or after Solomon.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel very pleased with what Solomon has requested; or
- I love that Solomon is humble and knows that he needs my help to be a good king; or
- I am happy to bless Solomon more than any other king because Solomon’s desire is to please me.

Ask the person playing Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Wow! I am amazed at Yahweh’s generosity; or
- I feel loved by Yahweh; or
- I feel like I have a relationship with Yahweh, like the strong relationship my father, David, had with Yahweh.

Ask the person playing the other kings that came before or after, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am amazed by the wealth and greatness of King Solomon; or
- We wish we were as famous and that Yahweh would honor us like he honored Solomon; or
- We feel jealous of Solomon.

Continue the drama.

In the second scene, Solomon left Gibeon and went from the Tent of Meeting back to Jerusalem. Solomon ruled Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am happy, blessed, and ready to rule; or
- I know Yahweh will be with me, and I feel more confident and prepared; or
- I feel loved by Yahweh. I feel secure and safe because Yahweh keeps his promises.

Ask the person playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We are very happy. Our King Solomon rules us very well; or
- We feel blessed, rich, and prosperous; or
- We feel that we are a special nation that Yahweh loves. Yahweh has blessed us with a good king.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7-13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

That night, **God** appeared to Solomon and asked Solomon to ask for anything, and God would give it to Solomon. God is a general name for Yahweh. God refers to God who created everything. God is the most powerful spiritual being. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon told Yahweh that Yahweh had shown great kindness, or steadfast love, to Solomon's father, David, by making Solomon king. Kindness refers to how Yahweh treats people who are under Yahweh's authority. This kindness is the steadfast, or loyal, love of Yahweh. Yahweh treated David with kindness because Yahweh had promised to do so, and Yahweh never breaks Yahweh's promises.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kindness** or **steadfast love**. Look up steadfast love in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Use the same word or phrase for **king** as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon asked **Yahweh** God to fulfill Yahweh's word or promise. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon said that it was Yahweh who had made Solomon king over a people who are as many as the dust of the earth. The people of Israel were too many to count.

Solomon asked Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom and knowledge so that Solomon might be able to go out and come in before the people. Solomon told Yahweh that no one would be able to judge Yahweh's great people. A person who has wisdom understands many things because they have experienced many things. That person is able to make good decisions that lead to good results. When a person has certain skills, like the ability to build or to make something beautiful, the Bible also says that this person has wisdom. It is Yahweh who gives wisdom to people. Knowledge is similar to wisdom; when someone has knowledge, that person has understanding. People can gain understanding more quickly, perhaps, than they can gain wisdom. This kind of knowledge also helps people lead others, make good choices, and understand the situation clearly. It is not just about knowing a lot of facts.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **wisdom** and **knowledge**. Look up wisdom in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

To go out and come in before the people is to lead the people. It is special language that usually refers to a king or commander leading his warriors to war, but here it means all the different ways that king Solomon would lead Israel. When someone judges or rules, that person usually decides cases and punishes those who are wrong, but not in this case. Solomon asks Yahweh, "Who is able to judge your great people?" Solomon means that no one can rule the people fairly.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **judge**, especially when it means to govern or rule a group of people fairly. Look up judge in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh said that Solomon's **heart desire** was not **possessions**, **riches**, or **honor**, or for Yahweh to kill Solomon's enemies, or for a long life for himself, but for wisdom and knowledge. A person's heart desire is the thing that the person wants more than anything else. Possessions and riches refer to things like land, animals, silver, or gold. If you have different words in your language to refer to these things, use two different words. If not, use one word. Honor may refer to beauty, respect, riches, or signs that God is with Solomon.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **heart desire**, **possessions**, **riches**, and **honor**. Look up **heart** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Then Solomon went to Jerusalem from the **high place** at Gibeon, from before the **Tent of Meeting** or tabernacle. And Solomon ruled Israel. Use the same words or phrases for “high place” and “Tent of Meeting” as you used in previous passages. For more information on the Tent of Meeting, or tabernacle, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 1:14–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Solomon asked God for wisdom and knowledge to be a good leader for Israel. God promised to make Solomon wise. God also promised that Solomon would be wealthy and famous. In this story, the storyteller describes the powerful army that Solomon built up for Israel.

Solomon’s army owned many horses and chariots. At that time, having horses and chariots made an army more powerful. A soldier could ride a horse, and the horse could run faster than humans, so the soldier on a horse could catch and kill more people than a soldier on foot.

A chariot is a kind of cart that horses pull into battle. At least two soldiers ride in the chariot. One soldier controls the horses while the other soldier can shoot arrows or stab enemy soldiers with his sword. The soldiers inside the chariot are also somewhat protected by the walls of the chariot.

Stop here and look at a picture of a chariot with soldiers inside. Pause this audio here.

Solomon had 1,400 chariots. When you listened to three different versions of this passage, some might have said that Solomon had 12,000 horses, while others said that Solomon had 12,000 horsemen. A horseman is a person who knows how to handle horses. Bible scholars do not agree on whether the original language means that Solomon had 12,000 horses or that Solomon had 12,000 horsemen.

Solomon stationed some of his horses and chariots in Jerusalem, and Solomon stationed others in special cities in Israel that Solomon built just for them. This made it easier to defend the country from invaders, because no matter where an enemy attacked, there would always be a chariot city close by.

Solomon bought horses from Egypt and also from a place called Kue. Bible scholars are not certain exactly where Kue was located, but some think it might have been located northwest of Israel, in the southeastern part of the modern-day country of Turkey. This area is sometimes called Cilicia. When you listened to three different versions of this passage, you might have heard the storyteller call this place Kue, or you might have heard the storyteller call this place Cilicia.

Stop here and look at a map of the Middle East that shows Israel and Turkey. Note the location of Cilicia. Pause this audio here.

Toward the end of this passage, the storyteller tells us how much Solomon paid for his chariots and horses. The price of a chariot was about 600 shekels of silver, and the price of a horse was about 150 shekels of silver. This was equal to about seven kilograms of silver for a chariot and about two kilograms of silver for a horse. The storyteller adds that Solomon's men sold chariots and horses to the kings of the Hittites and the kings of the Arameans.

As the storyteller tells us these things, the storyteller reminds us of just how rich Solomon was. Silver, gold, and cedar wood were all valuable, expensive items, but they were very common in Israel during Solomon's day. This meant that not only was Solomon very rich, but Solomon made his people quite rich as well.

Cedar wood was a kind of wood that was very good for building. Cedar was very strong, lasted a long time, and had a pleasant smell and color. The Israelites thought that the best cedar came from Lebanon, the country just north of Israel.

Stop here and look at a picture of a cedar tree. Have you ever seen a building that people made from cedar wood? What was it like?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one scene.

In the first scene: The storyteller tells us about Solomon's chariots and horses. The storyteller also tells us that Solomon was so rich that valuable materials like silver, gold, and cedar were extremely common in Israel.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Solomon's horsemen and charioteers
- Solomon's royal merchants
- And the kings of the Hittites and Arameans

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the author tells us about Solomon's chariots and horses. If you have already translated the book of 1 Chronicles, then you have already translated the word for chariot. It would be helpful to go back and listen to how you translated chariot in that book.

Stop here and listen to the first part of 1 Chronicles chapter 18, if it is available in your language. In this story, King David defeated King Hadadezer and took his chariots. Pay attention to how you translated the word chariot. Pause this audio here.

Solomon had 1,400 chariots, and either 12,000 horses or 12,000 horsemen. Bible scholars do not agree on whether the original language means to say "horses" or "horsemen" in this passage. Either translation choice is acceptable.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How common are horses in your culture? If horses are not common now, was there a time in the past when horses were common? What words do you use for a person who knows how to handle horses? What words do you have for a person who is a soldier who rides horses? Pause this audio here.

Solomon kept some of his horses, chariots, and charioteers in the chariot cities Solomon had built all over Israel, but Solomon kept some of them in Jerusalem to protect the capital city. Solomon bought horses from Egypt and from a place called Kue. Bible scholars are not certain exactly where Kue was. Bible scholars do know that during Solomon's time, an area in southeastern Turkey had a reputation for breeding excellent horses. Sometimes people called this area "Cilicia." When you listened to three different versions of this passage, you might have heard that Solomon bought horses from Egypt and Kue, or that Solomon bought horses from Egypt and Cilicia. Either translation choice is acceptable.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the location of Israel and the location of Cilicia. Pause this audio here.

Solomon bought a chariot for seven kilograms of silver and a horse for two kilograms of silver. Solomon's traders not only bought chariots and horses for Israel, but they also sold chariots and horses to the kings of the Hittites and the Arameans. The Hittites and Arameans were enemies of Israel, so it is not clear why Solomon's traders sold horses and chariots to these people. Perhaps Solomon was so rich and so powerful that Solomon no longer had to worry about attacks from the Hittites and the Arameans.

While the storyteller is describing Solomon's army, the storyteller mentions again that there was so much silver in Israel that it was as common as stones. The storyteller also claims that cedar trees were as common as sycamore trees in the lowlands. The Israelites had to import good-quality cedar into Israel from Lebanon, and it was expensive. In contrast, sycamore trees were very common in an area called Shephelah, which was the low hills in the region of Judah. Both of these statements mean that Solomon was so rich that Solomon could buy a lot of expensive things.

Stop here and look at a picture of a cedar tree. Does the cedar tree look like any trees that grow in your area? Next, look at a picture of a sycamore tree. Does this tree look like any trees that grow in your area? Pause this audio here.

In your language, it may be unnatural or confusing for the storyteller to first talk about Solomon's chariots and horses, then talk about Solomon's silver, gold, and cedar, and then go back to talking about Solomon's chariots and horses again. If this is the case, it is acceptable to move the storyteller's comments about silver, gold, and cedar to either the beginning or the end of this story.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one scene.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon

- Solomon’s horsemen and charioteers
- Solomon’s royal merchants
- And the kings of the Hittites and Arameans

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Solomon built up a large force of 1,400 chariots and 12,000 horsemen. Solomon stationed some of them in the chariot cities and some near Solomon in Jerusalem. The king made silver and gold as common in Jerusalem as stone, and he made cedar as common as the sycamore trees that grow in the foothills of Judah. Solomon’s horses came from Egypt and Kue, and the king’s merchants bought them from Kue at the standard price. They bought a chariot from Egypt for about seven kilograms of silver, and a horse for about two kilograms of silver. And they also exported chariots and horses to the kings of the Hittites and the Arameans.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I hope that these chariots and horsemen will keep our nation safe for many years to come; or
- I am making Israel the most powerful nation on earth; or
- I am very happy that my people now have great riches.

Ask the people playing Solomon’s royal merchants, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so proud that our country has enough money to buy good horses and chariots; or
- I am happy that our people have such a great king as Solomon; or
- I am glad that we can make extra money by selling horses and chariots to the Hittites and Arameans.

Ask the people playing Solomon’s horsemen and charioteers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Finally, our country has an army as powerful as Egypt’s; or
- I feel proud to serve in such a strong army; or
- I am grateful to King Solomon for providing such good chariots and horses for our army.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Solomon built up a large force of 1,400 **chariots** and 12,000 horsemen. Be sure to translate the word chariot the same way that you did in previous books of the Bible. If necessary, listen again to the beginning of 1 Chronicles chapter 18, when King David defeats Hadadezer and takes his chariots.

Stop here. If you decide to use the word “**horsemen**,” decide how you will translate it into your language. Pause this audio here.

Solomon stationed some of them in the chariot cities and some near Solomon in Jerusalem. Cities are larger settlements that often have a wall around them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **chariot cities**. Pause this audio here.

The **king** made silver and gold as common in Jerusalem as stone, and the king made cedar as common as the sycamore trees that grow in the foothills of Judah. Be sure to translate king the same way that you did in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on king.

Stop here and look again at a picture of a **cedar** tree and a **sycamore** tree. Decide what words you will use for these two trees. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Judah**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about Judah. Pause this audio here.

Solomon’s horses came from Egypt and Kue, and the king’s merchants bought them from Kue at the standard price.

Stop here and look again at a map of the Middle East that shows the locations of Israel, Turkey, and Cilicia. Decide whether you will use the name **Kue** or **Cilicia** for the place the horses came from. Pause this audio here.

Solomon’s traders bought a chariot from Egypt for about seven kilograms of silver, and a horse for about two kilograms of silver. And the traders also exported chariots and horses to the kings of the **Hittites** and the **Arameans**. Be sure to translate Hittites and Arameans the same way you did in previous passages. If you have already translated the book of Genesis, then you have already translated the word Hittite. If necessary, go back and listen to the beginning of Genesis chapter 36, which lists the wives of Esau. Esau’s wife, Adah, was the daughter of Elon the Hittite. You translated “Arameans” in 1 Chronicles chapter 18, in the story when King David defeats King Hadadezer and the Aramean army.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 2:1–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 2:1–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

You can also listen to your translation of the same story in 1 Kings 5:13–18 if you have already translated it. Since the storyteller tells this story in another way, pay attention to the differences in the order of the scenes as well as some of the details.

Pause this audio here.

This story starts with King Solomon's order to build a temple where people can worship the Name of Yahweh and a royal palace for King Solomon. People can gather at the temple to worship Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, where do people usually gather to worship their gods? Who builds those places? Pause this audio here.

Then King Solomon assigned workers to work on the project. Solomon assigned 70,000 workers to carry rocks that 80,000 other workers would cut out of the mountainside. The people will use these rocks to build the temple. Three thousand six hundred men will supervise these workers.

King Solomon sent a message to King Hiram of Tyre. Tyre was just north of Israel, in the present-day country of Lebanon. King Solomon knows that his father, King David, had a good relationship with King Hiram. King Solomon asks King Hiram to send cedar wood, just like when King Hiram sent cedar wood for King David in the past. At that time, people knew about Lebanon for its thick forests, which grew valuable cedar trees. Cedar wood is tough and beautiful. King Hiram sent wood for David's palace before, but this time King Solomon asks King Hiram for timber because King Solomon is about to build a temple that Solomon will dedicate to Yahweh.

King Solomon explains what the people will do at the temple to obey Yahweh's law. [The Israelites will burn incense, a mix of gum and spices that smell good. The Israelites will set out holy or special bread each week. The Israelites will offer burnt offerings every morning and evening, on every Sabbath, at the New Moon Festival, and on the other feast days.] The Sabbath was the seventh day of the week, and the Israelites did not work on that day; instead, the Israelites rested and honored Yahweh. In Old Testament times, the Israelites celebrated the festival of the New Moon at the beginning of each month, when the people could see the new moon rise in the sky. During this festival, the Israelites stopped their work, offered special sacrifices, and blew ram's horn trumpets to celebrate. These are the same things that people have been doing at Yahweh's tabernacle.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what practices or rituals do you do to worship God? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon plans to build a great temple for Yahweh. Solomon knows that Yahweh is the greatest of all the gods. In fact, Solomon knows that Solomon cannot build a temple that Yahweh can live in—in fact, even the heavens where Yahweh lives are not big enough for Yahweh!

King Solomon asks King Hiram to send someone who is skilled in craftsmanship. King Solomon specifically asks for a skilled worker to work with precious metals like gold, silver, bronze, and iron.

Stop here and look at a picture of gold, silver, bronze, and iron. Pause this audio here.

The skilled worker should also know how to work with high-quality materials like cloth or yarn, which people dyed to be the colors blue, purple, and red. These were expensive colors, so they often represented royalty. These were the same colors Yahweh had told the Israelites to use for the tabernacle.

King Solomon also wanted a skilled worker who knew how to do “engravings,” or carvings into wood, stone, or metal. King David already prepared skilled workers in Judah and Jerusalem, his capital city, in the past to build the temple, but you will remember that Yahweh did not allow King David to build the temple for Yahweh.

Stop here and look at pictures of blue, purple, and red cloth. Pause this audio here.

Then King Solomon asks King Hiram to send King Solomon lots of wood from cedar trees, juniper trees, and algum trees. We do not know if the juniper trees are juniper, cypress, or fir trees. We also do not know what type of tree the algum trees are. Some people think algum was a type of juniper tree, while others think it was a sandalwood tree. Since people will use this wood to build a large and magnificent temple, it was probably high-quality wood that people can polish and make shiny.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of cedar, Lebanese juniper, sandalwood, and cypress trees. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon is willing to pay King Hiram’s workers with 2,000 tons of wheat grain, 2,000 tons of barley grain, 400,000 liters of wine, and 400,000 liters of oil. Israel produces a great amount of wheat, barley, wine, and olive oil. These were the most common foods that people in Israel ate.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are the most common things that you grow for food in your land? What things do you normally trade with other people for? Pause this audio here.

King Hiram replies to King Solomon through a letter. King Hiram starts his letter and declares that King Solomon is proof that Yahweh loves the people of Israel. Then King Hiram praises Yahweh, who is the God of Israel, and who made heaven and earth. King Hiram continues to praise Yahweh, who gave King David a wise son, who is intelligent and full of discernment.

King Hiram will send the skilled craftsman named Hiram-Abi. Hiram-Abi’s mother was from the Israelite tribe of Dan, and Hiram-Abi’s father was from Tyre. The tribe of Dan is one of the 12 tribes of Israel. Hiram-Abi works with precious metals, high-quality yarn, and a special cloth that people wove from the flax plant called linen. Hiram-Abi can engrave and make any design that someone gives to him. Hiram-Abi will work with the skilled workers of King Solomon and those of King David to build the temple. Then King Hiram asks Solomon to send the wheat, barley, wine, and olive oil that King Solomon promised to give the workers. Finally, King Hiram tells how Hiram’s workers will transport the timbers from Lebanon to Jerusalem. The workers will cut the timbers and will make wood into rafts to float on the sea south to Joppa, another town along the coast of the sea. Then, from Joppa, King Solomon’s workers can take the timbers to Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel and Lebanon that shows Jerusalem, and also Tyre and Joppa along the coast. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon takes a census, or counts, all the foreigners who live in Israel, as King David had done before him. King Solomon counts 153,600 foreigners. King Solomon probably only counts the men. These are foreigners from other nations who live in Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you gather or force workers to build something for your whole people group? What kinds of people have to do the work? How does the leader treat those people? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller reminds us that from these foreigners, King Solomon assigns 70,000 men to carry the rocks and 80,000 men to be stonecutters in the hills. King Solomon also assigns 3,600 foremen to supervise the workers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you count how many people are in the nation? How do the leaders know who is part of different people groups? How do leaders treat the foreigners in their country?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1-18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: King Solomon orders his people to build a temple for Yahweh and a palace for King Solomon.

In the second scene: King Solomon asks King Hiram of Tyre to send King Solomon an expert craftsman and a lot of wood.

In the third scene: King Hiram of Tyre agrees to Solomon's request.

In the fourth scene: King Solomon takes a census of the foreigners in Israel for the building project.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- King Hiram of Tyre
- Hiram-Abi the craftsman
- Workers who will carry large rocks
- Workers who will cut the large rocks
- Supervisors
- Workers of King Hiram
- And foreigners in Israel

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, King Solomon orders the people to build a temple for the name of Yahweh and a royal palace for King Solomon. Though the storyteller mentions King Solomon's palace, the storyteller does not tell the story of how people built it. In that culture, someone's name represented who they were, so Solomon said that Solomon wanted Yahweh himself, or Yahweh's name, to live in the temple Solomon would build for Yahweh.

The storyteller first tells us about the workers that King Solomon forced to cut stones for the temple. However, we know from later in the story that King Solomon took a census, or counted all the foreigners, before Solomon chose these workers. King Solomon gathered 80,000 workers who would quarry and cut the large rocks, and 70,000 workers who would carry the rocks from the mountainside to Jerusalem. Solomon also assigned 3,600 officers who would supervise the workers. If it would be clearer in your language, you can talk about the workers who cut the stone before you talk about the workers who move the stones.

In the second scene, King Solomon sends a message to King Hiram of Tyre and asks King Hiram to send cedar timbers, just like what King Hiram did for King David when King David built a house for himself. Solomon emphasizes the fact that this time Solomon is building a temple for Yahweh. Solomon uses a word that means "Look!" or "Pay attention!" King Solomon will not only build his own house, but King Solomon will also build a temple for Yahweh, Solomon's God. Solomon emphasizes that Yahweh is Solomon's God. Solomon is completely devoted to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will show that Solomon emphasizes that Solomon is building a temple for Yahweh, unlike what David built before. Pause this audio here.

It will be a temple where people can go, do their religious duties, and worship Yahweh. People will do all the important things that people did in the tabernacle. You will remember that the Israelites burn incense in the tabernacle, and they set out the special bread of the presence on the table. Every week, the priests set out 12

loaves of bread on the golden table in the Holy Place in the tabernacle. In this temple, people will make burnt offerings every morning and evening, just as you remember they did in the tabernacle. People will make these burnt offerings on the Sabbath, during the New Moon Festivals, and at every other special festival, just like they did in the tabernacle. Yahweh has told the Israelites that they should do these things forever.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will show the regular actions that Solomon says the Israelites will do regularly in the temple. Review how you have translated incense, bread of the presence, burnt offerings, Sabbath, and New Moon Festivals in other books of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

This temple will be great because God is great, greater than other gods! Solomon asks several questions that Solomon does not expect anyone to answer. Solomon asks, “But who is able to build a temple for him, since the heavens, even the highest heavens, cannot contain him? Who then am I to build a temple for him, except as a place to burn sacrifices before him?” Solomon does this to show that Solomon understands that Solomon cannot build a house for Yahweh to live in. Even the heavens are not big enough to hold all of Yahweh. In this case, the “heavens, even the highest heavens,” refer to the sky and everything above the earth.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will show that Solomon understands that Solomon cannot build a house for Yahweh. How will you talk about the heavens being unable to hold all of Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

That is why King Solomon asks King Hiram to send a very skillful craftsman who can work with the other craftsmen and workers who build the temple. King Solomon wants a craftsman who is skilled in working with precious metals and precious fabrics and is also skillful in carving wood, stone, and metal. King Solomon also asks King Hiram to send a lot of wood for the building project. King Solomon wants the temple to be great and wonderful. King Solomon even assures King Hiram that King Solomon will send food to pay King Hiram’s workers. Solomon promises to send 20,000 cors of ground wheat grain, 20,000 cors of barley grain, 20,000 baths of wine, and 20,000 baths of olive oil. This is about 2,000 tons of wheat, 2,000 tons of barley, and 400,000 liters of olive oil and wine. These are very large amounts of wheat, barley, wine, and oil! You may just say that King Solomon sent King Hiram 20,000 measures each of wheat, barley, wine, and oil because we are not sure exactly how much of each of these things Solomon sent.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about how much of each item Solomon will send to King Hiram. If you have already translated 1 Kings 5:1-12, use the same units of measurement that you used in that passage. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, King Hiram agrees to Solomon’s request. King Hiram sends a letter to King Solomon. In the letter, King Hiram recognizes that Yahweh loves the Israelites very much. Yahweh has made Solomon king of Israel because Yahweh loves them so much! Then King Hiram also blesses, or praises, Yahweh because Solomon is wise and has a lot of knowledge. After that, King Hiram informs King Solomon that King Hiram will send Hiram-Abi, who is a very skilled craftsman. Hiram-Abi will supervise and work with the other craftsmen. Then King Hiram agrees to Solomon’s payments and asks Solomon to do what Solomon has promised. Hiram speaks very respectfully to Solomon. Hiram calls David and Solomon my lord, or master, and Hiram calls himself Solomon’s servant!

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do two leaders of different people groups or countries usually talk to each other in a way that shows they respect each other? Pause this audio here.

King Hiram’s workers are ready to supply all the wood that King Solomon needs. King Hiram’s workers will make the wood into rafts and deliver them to Joppa. And then from Joppa, King Solomon’s workers will bring the wood to Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at the map that shows the wood moving from Tyre to Joppa to Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, King Solomon makes a record, or census, of all the male foreigners who are living in the land of Israel, as his father David did. We are not sure if this means that King Solomon uses the numbers David counted, or if King Solomon makes this record in a similar way to the way his father, David, did. The census numbers 153,600 people.

The storyteller reminds us that from this census, Solomon assigns 80,000 workers to quarry and cut the rocks. Then King Solomon assigns 70,000 workers to carry the rocks from the mountainside to Jerusalem, where they

will build the temple. Then King Solomon assigns the remaining 3,600 as foremen to supervise the workers. These are the same groups of men that the storyteller told us about at the beginning of the passage. This means that Solomon must have taken the census before Solomon assigned the men to these jobs.

Stop here and discuss as a group: [How will you make it clear that these are the same groups of men from the beginning of the story? Pause this audio here.]{mark}

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1-18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- King Hiram of Tyre
- Hiram-Abi the craftsman
- Workers who will carry large rocks
- Workers who will cut the large rocks
- Supervisors
- Workers of King Hiram
- And foreigners in Israel

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, King Solomon orders the people to build a temple for Yahweh and a royal palace for King Solomon. King Solomon gathers the workers who will quarry and cut the large rocks, and then King Solomon gathers the workers who will carry the rocks from the mountainside to Jerusalem. Solomon assigns the supervisors to supervise the work.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, “What were you thinking when you decided to build a temple for Yahweh?” The person might answer things like:

- I must do what my father, David, wanted and build a temple for Yahweh; or
- I think I need to honor Yahweh because Yahweh brought peace to Israel. I will build a temple to honor Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

In the second scene, King Solomon sends a message to King Hiram of Tyre and asks King Hiram to give cedar timbers because King Solomon will build a temple for Yahweh and a palace for Solomon. King Solomon also asks King Hiram to send a very skillful craftsman who can work with the other craftsmen and workers to build the temple. In return, King Solomon will send food to the workers.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, “What were you feeling or thinking when you asked King Hiram for his support in building the temple?” The person might answer things like:

- I think King Hiram will not refuse me in honor of my father, King David’s treaty with King Hiram;
- I think King Hiram has the workers and resources I need to help build the temple.

Continue the drama.

In the third scene, King Hiram supports King Solomon’s plan to build the temple. King Hiram sends a letter that recognizes that Yahweh loves the Israelites very much. King Hiram also praises Yahweh because Yahweh chose a wise king to rule Israel. Then King Hiram informs King Solomon that King Hiram sent Hiram-Abi, a very skilled craftsman. Hiram-Abi will work alongside the craftsmen of King Solomon and King David as they build the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hiram, “What were you feeling or thinking when King Solomon asked you to support King Solomon as he builds a temple for Yahweh?” The person might answer things like:

- King Solomon honors me when he asks me to help build the temple for Yahweh; or
- I had a treaty with King David. Now I want to keep that treaty with his son, King Solomon.

Ask the person playing Hiram-Abi, “What were you feeling or thinking when you found out that you would help build the temple in Jerusalem?” The person might answer things like:

- King Hiram honors me because he has chosen me to help build the temple for Yahweh; or
- I think this is my chance to worship Yahweh through my skills.

Continue the drama.

In the fourth scene, King Solomon counts all the foreigners who are living in the land of Israel and assigns some of them as workers and foremen.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing foreigners that King Solomon assigns to work on building the temple, “What were you feeling or thinking when you found out that you would help build the temple?” The people might answer things like:

- We feel honored for such an opportunity to help build the temple for Yahweh; or
- We feel we belong to the people of Israel; or
- I do not like that Solomon is forcing us to do this very hard work. Let Solomon find someone else to do this work!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1-18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Solomon orders the people to build a temple for the **Name of Yahweh** and a royal palace for Solomon. Yahweh is God’s personal name. In that culture, someone’s name represented who that person was, so Solomon said that he wanted Yahweh himself, or Yahweh’s Name, to live in the temple Solomon would build for Yahweh. A temple is a place where people worship God. It is a place where God meets with people. Kings and rulers live in a palace with their families.

Use the same word for Yahweh that you have used previously. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **temple**. Look up the word temple in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for a **palace**, or a king’s house. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon gathers the workers who will quarry and cut the large rocks and the workers who will carry the rocks from the mountainside to Jerusalem. Solomon assigns the foremen or overseers to supervise the work.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for each group of **workers** and **overseers**. Pause this audio here.

Solomon sends a message to **King** Hiram of Tyre and asks King Hiram to give **cedar** timbers for building the temple and palace. Use the same words for king and cedar that you have used in previous passages. Refer to king in the Master Glossary for more information.

King Solomon says that people will burn incense in the temple. Incense is a mixture of sweet-smelling spices that makes a sweet-smelling smoke when people burn it.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **incense**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. If you have translated the book of Exodus, listen to Exodus 30:34-38. Pause this audio here.

Solomon also says that people will put the bread of the Presence in the temple. The bread of the Presence was 12 loaves of bread that priests put on the table in the Holy Place of the tabernacle, and later, in the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **bread of the Presence**. Look up the phrase “bread of the Presence” in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. If you have translated 1 Chronicles 9:32, you may listen to your translation to hear how you translated this type of bread there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon says that people will give **burnt offerings** morning and evening, on the Sabbaths, new moons, and other special festivals that Yahweh, the **God of Israel**, commanded the people to celebrate. Burnt offerings are animal sacrifices that people give, which the priest completely burns on the altar. The Sabbath is a special day of rest and worship. The new moon is the first day when people see a new moon in the sky. The Israelites had a special festival on that day. There are also other festivals that Yahweh told the people to celebrate each year. Use the same words for burnt offering, God, and Israel that you have used previously. See the Master Glossary for more information about burnt offerings, God, and Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Sabbath**, **new moon**, and **festivals**. Look up Sabbath and “festival of the new moon” in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon says that the house that Solomon will build for God is great because the God of Israel is greater than all other gods. But God is so great that no one can build a house big enough for God. God is bigger than the highest heavens. Some people worship other supernatural beings or gods who are not Yahweh. Yahweh is greater than these false gods. In this context, “heavens” refers to the sky and everything above the earth.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **gods** and **heavens**. Look up gods and heavens in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon also asks King Hiram to send a very skillful craftsman who knows how to work with metals like gold, silver, **bronze**, and iron. The craftsman must be able to work with purple, red, and blue precious fabrics and who can engrave or carve in wood, stone, and metal. This craftsman will work with the other craftsmen in **Jerusalem** and **Judah** that Solomon’s father, **David**, provided. Use the same words for bronze, Jerusalem, Judah, and David that you have used in previous passages. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about bronze, Jerusalem, Judah, and David.

Stop here and look again at a photo of **purple**, **red**, and **blue** cloth. Discuss as a group how you will describe the purple, red, and blue cloth. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks King Hiram to send King Solomon lots of wood from cedar trees, juniper trees, and algum trees, because Hiram’s **servants** are skilled at cutting trees. We do not know whether the trees are juniper, cypress, or fir. We also do not know what type of tree the algum trees are. Some people think algum was a type

of juniper tree, while others think it was a sandalwood tree. Use the same word for servant that you have used in previous passages. Refer to servant in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and look at a picture of cedar, Lebanese juniper, sandalwood, and cypress trees, if needed. How will you call **cedar**, **juniper**, and **cypress** trees in your language? If you have translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and decide how you will translate **algum wood** into your language. If necessary, look again at the pictures of a sandalwood tree and a juniper tree, which might look like the trees that the storyteller mentions here. Will you use a word for an existing kind of wood from your language, or will you translate it to sound like the word in the original language? Pause this audio here.

Solomon promises to send 20,000 cors of ground wheat grain, 20,000 cors of barley grain, 20,000 baths of **wine**, and 20,000 baths of olive oil to the workers who cut the wood. A cor is a dry measurement equal to about 6 bushels or 220 liters. A bath is a liquid measure equal to about 22 liters. This is about 2,000 tons of wheat, 2,000 tons of barley, and 400,000 liters of olive oil and wine. These are very large amounts of wheat, barley, wine, and oil! You may just say that King Solomon sent King Hiram 20,000 measures each of wheat, barley, wine, and oil. Use the same word for wine that you have used in previous passages. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about wine.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about how much of each item Solomon will send to King Hiram. If you have already translated 1 Kings 5:1-12, use the same units of measurement that you used in that passage. Pause this audio here.

King Hiram sends a letter back to King Solomon. Hiram says, “**Praise** or **bless** Yahweh, the God of Israel. God has given King David a **wise** son, who is intelligent and full of understanding.” Use the same words for praise or bless and wise that you have used in previous passages. For more information, refer to praise, bless, and wisdom in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe that Solomon is wise and understands a lot of things. The words for being **intelligent** and **understanding** describe someone who knows a lot of facts but also understands how to use that knowledge for the good of other people. Pause this audio here.

King Hiram tells Solomon that Hiram has sent Hamur-Abi, a skilled craftsman, to work with Solomon’s craftsmen and the craftsmen of “my lord David.” When Hiram calls David “my **lord**,” Hiram is using a term of respect and authority. Use the same word for lord that you have used in previous passages. For more information, refer to lord in the Master Glossary.

King Solomon takes a census of all the foreigners living in Israel, just like Solomon’s father, King David, had done. A census is when a ruler or government counts the number of people. A person is a foreigner or a stranger in a country when they are in a country that is not where that person was born. There are different types of foreigners. In this context, foreigners are non-Israelites who are living permanently in Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **foreigner**. Use the same word for foreigners that you have used in other books of the Bible, when it is this kind of foreigner. For more information about foreigners, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **census**, or when a leader counts the number of a certain type of people in his kingdom.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 3:1-14

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 3:1-14 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1-14 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1-14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, you heard about Solomon's preparations to build the temple. Solomon got the materials and workers to help build a temple for Yahweh.

In this passage, Solomon begins to build a temple for Yahweh. This temple is a place where people will worship Yahweh.

The information in this passage is also in 1 Kings 6:1-13 and 1 Kings 6:14-38. If you have already translated those passages, stop here and listen to your translation as a group. Pause this audio here.

Solomon builds the temple in Jerusalem on Mount Moriah, the place where Abraham went to sacrifice Abraham's son, Isaac. Solomon's father, David, chose this place to build Yahweh's temple because Yahweh appeared to David there. Before Yahweh appeared to David, this place belonged to a man named Araunah, who was a Jebusite, someone who was part of the Jebus people. Some translations call Araunah by the name Ornan. This was the threshing floor or the place where Araunah threshed or separated his grain from the rest of the plant. Solomon begins to build the temple on the second day of the second month of the year in Israel. Solomon begins to build during the fourth year Solomon is king over Israel.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Jerusalem and Mount Moriah. Look at a picture of a threshing floor. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon lays the foundation for the temple of Yahweh, which is 60 cubits, or 30 meters, long and 20 cubits, or 10 meters, wide. A cubit is a way to measure how long something is. One cubit is about as long as the distance between a man's elbow and the tips of his fingers, or about 50 centimeters. At this time, the people of Israel probably had two different lengths for a cubit, and Solomon uses the older standard measurement for a cubit. The portico or porch at the front of the temple is 20 cubits, or 10 meters, wide, like the rest of the building. A portico, which people sometimes call a porch, is part of a structure that has columns instead of walls to hold up the roof. The portico is probably only 20 cubits high. Solomon uses pure gold to cover the inside of the portico.

Solomon covers the inside of the main area of the temple with wood planks. This wood could be from cypress, fir, or juniper trees. Those types of wood were very hard and lasted a long time. Solomon covers the wood planks with pure gold and makes designs of palm trees and decorative chains on the walls. Palm trees are tall trees in Israel, and palm trees can be symbols of fertility, life, plentiful crops, and Yahweh's blessing on Yahweh's people. Solomon uses expensive stones to make the main area of the temple beautiful and uses gold from the land of Parvaim, which probably means the gold was pure or of very good quality. We are not sure where Parvaim may have been located. Solomon covers the ceiling beams, door frames, walls, and doors in the main area of the temple with gold. Men carve pictures of angels called cherubim on the walls. You will remember from 1 Chronicles that cherubim are winged creatures that are part human and part animal. The cherubim represent Yahweh's majesty and Yahweh's presence. Cherubim also protect Yahweh's property and serve as a throne for a king.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of palm trees, expensive stones, and gold metal. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon also builds the room called the Most Holy Place. Any place, person, or object that people dedicate to Yahweh is holy. The Most Holy Place is a place set apart for Yahweh's presence to live.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kinds of places or objects in your culture do people set apart to use for special reasons? Pause this audio here.

The Most Holy Place is 20 cubits, or 10 meters, long, just like the rest of the temple building. This room is also 20 cubits wide. Workmen use 600 talents of pure gold to cover the inside of the room. A talent is a way to measure how heavy something is, and 600 talents would weigh the same as about 21 metric tons. However, this amount may not be exact. Instead, 600 talents could represent how much gold there would be if each of the 12 tribes of Israel gave 50 tons of gold, or it could represent one year of income for Solomon.

Solomon uses gold nails for the Most Holy Place that weigh about 50 shekels. A shekel is another way to measure how heavy something is, and 50 shekels would weigh the same as about 600 grams. People probably made the nails out of iron and then covered the nails with gold. Solomon also covers the upper rooms with gold. We are not sure what these upper rooms may have been, but this may refer to the open space between the Most Holy Place and the ceiling of the rest of the temple.

For the Most Holy Place, men carve two cherubs out of wood, and the men cover the cherubim with gold. Together, the two cherubim's wings measure 20 cubits, or 10 meters, and the wings touched both sides of the room. The cherubim stand on their feet and look out from the Holy of Holies toward the main room of the temple. Solomon probably uses the cherubim to protect the Most Holy Place and to represent Yahweh's presence that lived there.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of cherubim. Pause this audio here.

Solomon weaves a curtain with fine linen and blue, purple, and red yarn and sews pictures of cherubim in it. Yarn is a thread that people spin and then use to weave cloth, and linen is cloth that people weave from flax plants. The curtain separates the main area of the temple from the Most Holy Place because Yahweh's presence lived in the Most Holy Place. Only the high priest, after he had made sacrifices for his sins, could enter Yahweh's presence one time per year.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a curtain. Look at a picture of blue, purple, and red yarn.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1-14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Solomon begins to build Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem, on Mount Moriah. David chose this place to build Yahweh's temple because Yahweh had appeared to David there.

In the second scene: Solomon builds the foundation of the temple. The foundation is 60 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. The portico at the front is also 20 cubits wide and 20 cubits high. Solomon covers the inside of the temple with gold and carves cherubim on the walls.

In the third scene: Solomon builds the Most Holy Place at the rear of the temple, and it is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. Gold covers the upper parts of the room as well. Solomon builds two cherubim and covers them with gold. The wings touch opposite walls of the Most Holy Place, and the wings touch each other in the middle of the room. Solomon also weaves a curtain that separates the Most Holy Place from the main area of the temple.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Workers who build the temple and decorate the temple
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Solomon begins to build a temple for Yahweh. Solomon builds the temple in Jerusalem, on Mount Moriah. Yahweh had sent Abraham to sacrifice Isaac on Mount Moriah, but we are not sure if this mountain in Jerusalem is the same Mount Moriah where Abraham traveled. However, this site in Jerusalem is the place that David, Solomon's father, chose as the place to build a temple for Yahweh. Yahweh appeared to David at this place. At the time that Yahweh appeared to David, Araunah the Jebusite used this site as a place to thresh grain. The storyteller talks about Mount Moriah and David because these things are important to the people of Israel. The place where Solomon builds the temple should show how important Yahweh's temple should be to the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about a place that is important to people in your culture. What kind of language do you use to let people know this place is important? Pause this audio here.

Solomon begins construction on the second day of the second month of the year, which would have been in the middle of spring, when the weather gets warmer and plants begin to grow. Solomon starts building in his fourth year as king over Israel.

In this passage, even though the storyteller talks about how Solomon builds the temple, Solomon actually directs many men to build and to decorate the temple. When the storyteller says Solomon built the temple, we know that Solomon directs his workers to do the work.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about this so that people will understand that many people worked on the temple even though the passage only talks about Solomon? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Solomon begins to build the foundation of the temple. In Solomon's culture, a foundation is part of the structure of a building that supports the building and provides stability. People usually placed strong rocks at the bottom of the structure and built on top of that. The foundation of the temple is 60 cubits long and 20 cubits wide, using the older cubit measurement. During this time, people probably used two different lengths to measure a cubit, and Solomon used the older standard length. The portico or porch at the entrance to the temple was 20 cubits wide and 20 cubits high.

Solomon covers the inside of the temple with pure gold. First, Solomon covers the walls of the temple with wood planks, and then Solomon covers those planks with gold. The walls have pictures of palm trees and decorative chains on them. Solomon probably carves the pictures of palm trees and chains on the wooden walls. People made chains out of metal links that they connected together. Solomon uses expensive or precious stones to decorate the temple and to make it beautiful. The workmen may have laid these stones in patterns on the floor of the main area of the temple. The gold Solomon uses comes from the land of Parvaim, but we do not know where

this land may have been. Solomon covers the ceiling beams, doorframes, walls, and doors with gold. Solomon orders craftsmen to carve pictures of cherubim, or angels, into the walls of the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture decorate important religious places? How do people talk about these special places? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, Solomon builds the Most Holy Place. The Most Holy Place is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. From another passage in the Bible, we know that the Most Holy Place is also 20 cubits high. Solomon uses 600 talents of fine gold to cover the walls of the Most Holy Place. This amount of gold may be the exact amount used, or it may represent a gift from the 12 tribes of Israel or a donation from Solomon's income.

Solomon uses gold nails in the construction of the Most Holy Place. The gold nails weigh about 50 shekels. Workers probably make these nails from iron and cover them with gold. Solomon also covers the upper parts of the Most Holy Place with gold. We do not know exactly what the upper parts of the Most Holy Place were.

Inside the Most Holy Place, Solomon carves two cherubim, or angels. Men probably make the cherubim from wood and then cover the cherubim with gold. Each cherub has two wings. The total length of the cherubim's wings is 20 cubits. The first cherub has one wing that measures 5 cubits long, and the wing touches one wall of the Most Holy Place. The other wing of the first cherub also measures 5 cubits, and it touches one of the wings of the second cherub in the middle of the Most Holy Place. In the same way, the second cherub has one wing that measures 5 cubits long and touches the wall on the other side of the Most Holy Place. The second wing of the second cherub also measures 5 cubits long, and it touches the wing of the first cherub in the middle of the Most Holy Place. Again, the total length of all the cherubim's wings is 20 cubits. The cherubim stand on their feet, and the cherubim look out from the Most Holy Place toward the main area of the temple.

Solomon's workmen make a curtain that separates the main area of the temple from the Most Holy Place. Craftsmen weave the curtain with fine linen and cloth that people wove with blue, purple, and red yarn. The craftsmen weave cherubim into the design of the curtain.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1-14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Workers who build the temple and decorate the temple
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Solomon begins to build Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem, on Mount Moriah. David chose this place to build Yahweh's temple because Yahweh had appeared to David there, where Araunah the Jebusite threshed grain. Solomon begins to build the temple in mid-spring, on the second day of the second month of the year. Solomon had been king for four years when Solomon began to build the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that David chose this place for my temple because this place is important; or
- I am pleased that Solomon is continuing the work of building my temple that Solomon's father, David, began.

Continue the drama.

Solomon builds the foundation of the temple using the old measure of a cubit. The foundation is 60 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. The portico at the front of the temple is also 20 cubits wide, and it is probably 20 cubits high. Solomon covers the entire inside of the temple with pure gold. Solomon uses wood planks for the walls of the temple and then covers those planks with gold. In the gold, Solomon's men carve palm trees and chain patterns to decorate the walls. Solomon uses expensive stones to decorate the temple. The pure gold Solomon uses comes from the land of Parvaim. Solomon covers the ceiling beams, doorframes, walls, and doors in the temple with gold and decorates the walls with cherubim.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing workers who build and decorate the temple, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are happy to get to build the temple for Yahweh; or
- We work hard to make Yahweh's temple beautiful according to Solomon's plans; or
- We are proud to use our strength and our skills to serve Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

Solomon builds the Most Holy Place at the rear of the temple. The Most Holy Place is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. Solomon covers the inside with 600 talents of pure gold and uses nails that craftsmen covered with gold that weigh 50 shekels. Solomon covers the upper parts of the room with gold as well. Solomon builds two cherubim and covers each cherub with gold. Each cherub has two wings, and each wing is 5 cubits long. The first cherub has one wing that touches a wall, and its other wing touches a wing of the second cherub. The second cherub has one wing that touches the other wall, and one wing that touches the wing of the first cherub. The cherubim stand on their feet and look out from the Most Holy Place toward the main area of the temple. Solomon also weaves a curtain made of blue, purple, and red yarn and fine linen. Workers sew images of cherubim into the curtain, and people hang the curtain so that it separates the Most Holy Place from the main area of the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel excited to build Yahweh's temple and to decorate it with such beautiful materials; or
- I feel humbled that Yahweh allows me to build the temple even though my father, David, planned to build it.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1-14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

If you have already translated 1 Kings 6:1-13 and 1 Kings 6:14-38, listen to your translation again to remind yourselves which words you used to translate that passage. Pause this audio here.

Solomon begins to build the **temple** for **Yahweh**. The temple is the place where the Israelites worshiped Yahweh. Yahweh is the name God gave himself. This name reminds people of God's covenant with the Israelites. Use the same words or phrases for temple and Yahweh that you used in previous passages. For more information on temple and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon builds the temple in **Jerusalem**, where Yahweh appeared to Solomon's father, **David**. David established Jerusalem as the capital of Israel. Use the same words or phrases for Jerusalem and David as you used in previous passages. For more information on Jerusalem and David, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon lays the foundation for the temple of **God**, and it is 60 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. Use the same word for God as you have used previously, and refer to God in the Master Glossary for more information.

The portico at the front of the temple is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits high. A cubit is a way to measure how long something is. One cubit is about as long as a man's arm from his elbow to his fingertips, or 50 centimeters. A portico, which people sometimes call a porch, is part of a structure that has columns instead of walls to hold up the roof.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **cubit** and **portico**. Look up cubit in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon covers the entire main hall with wood planks that people made from **cypress**, **fir**, or **juniper** trees. Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for this wood. Use the same word you have used in the previous passage.

Solomon covers the entire inside of the temple with pure **gold**. Gold is a yellow precious metal that people use to make jewelry and for decoration. Use the same word or phrase for gold as you used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of gold metal. Pause this audio here.

Solomon covers every part of the inside of the temple with gold. Solomon covers the ceiling beams, door frames, walls, and doors with gold. People make ceiling beams from wood. Then, people place these beams across the tops of a building's walls to help support the roof. People make door frames out of wood to decorate and give stability to a doorway. People use walls to help give structure to a building and to hold up the roof. People use doors as openings to move into and out of a building, and as openings to move between rooms of a building.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **ceiling beams**, **door frames**, **walls**, and **doors**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words or phrases that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon uses wood panels for the walls and covers them with gold. Solomon uses expensive stones to decorate the temple. Solomon also carves pictures of palm trees, chain patterns, and cherubim into the gold walls. A cherub is a type of angel, and cherubim means more than one angel. Cherubim seem to guard especially holy or sacred places.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of **cherubim**. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for cherubim. Look up cherubim in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon builds the Most Holy Place, and it is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. The Most Holy Place contained the two cherubim that Solomon carved and the ark of the covenant. Yahweh lived in the Most Holy Place, and no one was allowed to enter the Most Holy Place except Yahweh's high priest.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Most Holy Place**. Look up Most Holy Place in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon weaves a curtain that Solomon made of fine linen and blue, purple, and red yarn to separate the Most Holy Place from the rest of the temple. A curtain is a piece of material that people hang from the top to create a covering or screen.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of blue, purple, and red yarn. Look at a picture of a **curtain**. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for curtain, and remind yourselves of the words you used for the colors blue, purple, and red in the previous passage. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, you heard about how Solomon built Yahweh's temple at the site that David, Solomon's father, had chosen. Solomon covered the entire inside of the temple, which includes the main hall and the Most Holy Place, with gold. Solomon carved decorations into the walls and placed a curtain in front of the Most Holy Place.

Stop here and listen: If you have already translated 1 Kings 7:13–39, which contains the same information, listen to your translation of that passage as a group. Pause this audio here.

In this passage, the storyteller continues to describe how Solomon decorates the outside of the temple and makes objects for people to use in worship. However, the storyteller does not tell us exactly who does the work.

From another passage in the Bible, we know Solomon commands a man named Hiram from the city of Tyre to create all the bronze objects outside the temple.

In front of the temple, Solomon builds two pillars. We know from another passage in the Bible that Solomon makes these pillars out of bronze. Solomon probably makes these pillars for decoration, and the pillars are probably not connected to the temple building. These pillars measure about 35 cubits or 16 meters high. People use cubits to measure length. In another passage of the Bible, the storyteller measures each pillar to be 18 cubits high. In this passage, the storyteller might be talking about how long the two pillars are when someone lays them down one after the other. Together, the pillars measure 35 cubits long. Or the storyteller might be adding up different measurements of just one pillar, like the pillar's height, width, and circumference, to get the same measurement of 35 cubits.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a pillar. Pause this audio here.

On top of each pillar, Solomon puts a bronze capital, or a special decorative top. These capitals measure 5 cubits or 2.5 meters high. Solomon decorates the capitals with bronze chains that may have looked like braids. Solomon makes 100 bronze images that look like pomegranates and hangs them from the chains. Pomegranates are reddish fruits about the size of a human fist. Solomon attaches the pomegranates to the chains. From another passage in the Bible, we know Solomon decorates each capital with 2 chains and 200 pomegranates.

Stop here and look at a picture of metal braided chains and a picture of pomegranates. Pause this audio here.

Solomon sets the pillars in front of the temple. Solomon puts one pillar to the right or south of the temple entrance. Solomon names this pillar Jakin, which means, “Yahweh will establish.” Solomon puts the other pillar to the left or north side of the temple entrance. Solomon names this pillar Boaz, which means, “strength is in Yahweh.” Solomon may name the pillars this way to remind the people that Yahweh lives in the temple.

Solomon makes an altar out of bronze that measures 20 cubits or 9 meters long, 20 cubits or 9 meters wide, and 10 cubits or 4.5 meters high. These measurements may be for the base or foundation of the altar, and stairs may have led up to a platform. An altar is a place where people make sacrifices to Yahweh. An altar is like a table or platform where people put sacrifices, and people often burn these sacrifices on the altar.

Stop here as a group and look at a drawing of the altar. Discuss as a group: How do people worship gods in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Then Solomon makes a large round basin from bronze, and Solomon names the basin “the Sea.” The Sea measures 10 cubits, or 4.5 meters, across from edge to edge and 5 cubits, or just over 2 meters, high. People use a piece of string to measure around the rim of the Sea. The rim is 30 cubits or 13.5 meters around the circumference. Below the rim of the Sea, Solomon places figures to decorate the Sea. These figures may look like oxen bulls, but in another passage in the Bible, the storyteller says these decorations look like gourds, which are melon-like fruits. Solomon uses 10 figures for every cubit all the way around the Sea and places them in two rows. Solomon casts the figures at the same time as the Sea and uses one mold for it all.

Solomon places the Sea on the figures of 12 large bulls that people probably make out of bronze or stone. These bulls are much larger than the decorations around the rim of the Sea. Three bulls face north, three face west, three face south, and three face east. The Sea sits on the backs of the bulls, and the bulls all face outward. The Sea is about a handbreadth thick, or about the width of four fingers or 8 centimeters. Solomon shapes the edge of the Sea to look like the rim of a cup or like the petals of a lily. A lily is a large red or white flower with petals that curve outward from the center. In this passage, the storyteller says the Sea holds 3,000 baths of water. In another passage in the Bible, the storyteller says the Sea holds 2,000 baths of water. We do not know exactly how many liters are in one bath, but the Sea probably holds between 40,000 and 80,000 liters of water.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a bull and a picture of a lily. Pause this audio here.

Next, Solomon makes 10 smaller basins for washing. Solomon probably places five basins on the south side and five basins on the north side of the temple entrance, or Solomon may place the basins on the south and north sides of the Sea. People use the basins to wash either the things they use to offer burnt offerings or to wash the animals before people sacrifice the animals. A burnt offering is a form of sacrifice that people bring to Yahweh. However, priests use the Sea to wash their hands and feet.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the smaller wash basins. Pause this audio here.

Solomon then makes 10 lampstands out of gold, and Solomon makes them exactly the way Yahweh says people should make these lampstands. Yahweh may have told King David how to make the lampstands, and then David told Solomon. We do not know exactly how the lampstands looked, but they probably had several wicks like candles that people could light. Solomon places the lampstands inside the main hall of the temple, with five on the south side and five on the north side. Solomon also makes 10 tables and places them in the main hall of the temple with the lampstands, 5 on the south side and 5 on the north side. From another passage in the Bible, we know Solomon probably makes the tables out of wood and covers them with gold. We do not know if Solomon puts the lampstands on the tables or if Solomon uses the tables for the bread that represents Yahweh's presence. Solomon also makes 100 small gold bowls. People probably use these bowls to hold the blood of animals before they sprinkle the blood on the altar.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a gold lampstand. Pause this audio here.

Solomon builds walls around the inner court where only priests could enter. Solomon also builds walls and doors for the larger court, where any person could enter. Solomon covers the doors with bronze.

Stop here and look at a diagram of the two different courtyards in Solomon's temple. Pause this audio here.

Solomon places the Sea on the southeastern side of the temple.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Solomon makes two large bronze pillars to stand in the front entrance of the temple. Solomon decorates the pillars with chains and pomegranates and names the pillars Jakin and Boaz.

In the second scene: Solomon makes the altar and the Sea. Solomon decorates the Sea with figures and places the Sea on the backs of 12 large bull statues that all face outward.

In the third scene: Solomon makes 10 wash basins, 10 gold lamp stands, 10 tables, and 100 small gold bowls. Solomon builds walls and doors for the inner and outer courtyards. Solomon puts the Sea at the southeast corner of the temple.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Hiram—even though the storyteller does not mention Hiram's name in this passage, we know Hiram is the main worker
- Workers who help Hiram
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, Solomon makes two large bronze pillars for the front of the temple. We know from another passage in the Bible that Solomon did not actually make the pillars. Instead, Solomon commands a man named Hiram from the city of Tyre to cast or mold objects out of bronze. Even though the storyteller says Solomon makes the pillars and many other bronze objects in this passage, we know that Solomon commands Hiram to make things out of bronze.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you show that Solomon himself did not do the construction work on the temple, but Solomon ordered workers to do it? Pause this audio here.

As you translate this passage, you may find several different ways to interpret some of the words and measurements. You may want to follow the interpretation of the Bible you use for translation. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the pillars 35 cubits tall. Solomon also makes capitals, or decorative tops, for the tops of each pillar that measure 5 cubits high. Solomon decorates the capitals with bronze chains and images of pomegranates. Each pillar has two chains with 100 pomegranates attached to each chain. Solomon puts the pillars in front of the temple entrance. Solomon puts one pillar on the south or right side of the entrance, and Solomon names the pillar Jakin, which means “Yahweh will establish.” Solomon places the other pillar on the north or left side of the temple entrance, and Solomon names this pillar Boaz, which means “strength is in Yahweh.” We do not know if these pillars hold up the roof of the porch, or if they are standing on their own.

In the second scene, Solomon makes a bronze altar that measures 20 cubits long, 20 cubits wide, and 10 cubits high. You will remember that a cubit measures about 50 centimeters long. We do not know exactly how the altar looks, but we know people use it to offer animals as burnt offerings when they worship Yahweh. Next, Solomon makes a large, round bronze basin and names it “the Sea.” The Sea measures 10 cubits across from rim to rim, and the Sea is 5 cubits high. To measure all the way around the Sea, people use a piece of string that measures 30 cubits.

Below the rim all the way around the Sea, Solomon places decorations in two rows. For every cubit around the Sea, Solomon uses 10 figures for decoration. In this passage, the storyteller says the figures look like bulls. Bulls are large animals with four legs. These bulls were probably oxen, which means someone had castrated them. In another passage in the Bible, however, the storyteller says the decorations around the Sea look like gourds, which are fruits that look like melons. Solomon makes the Sea and the figure decorations all at once with the same mold.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you describe the decorations Solomon uses around the Sea? Remember that you can follow the interpretation of the Bible you use for translation when different interpretations of the same words may exist. Pause this audio here.

Solomon places the Sea on 12 large figures that look like bulls. The Sea sits on the backs of the bulls, and the bulls face outward. Three bulls face in each direction, north, west, south, and east. The Sea measures a handbreadth thick, and Solomon makes the rim curve outward like the rim of a cup or the petals on a lily. The Sea can hold 3,000 baths. People use baths to measure the volume of liquids. We are not sure exactly how many liters may be in a bath, but the Sea probably held between 40,000 and 80,000 liters.

In the third scene, Solomon makes 10 smaller wash basins out of bronze. Solomon puts the wash basins outside the temple, 5 on the south side and 5 on the north side. People use these smaller wash basins to wash the things they use to sacrifice animals or to wash the animals that people will burn as offerings to Yahweh. But the priests use the Sea to wash their hands and feet.

Next, Solomon makes 10 lampstands out of gold according to the instructions Yahweh had given. Solomon puts these lampstands inside the main hall of the temple, 5 on the south side of the hall and 5 on the north side. Solomon also makes 10 tables for the main hall inside the temple. Solomon puts 5 on the south and 5 on the north side of the main hall. Solomon may have placed the lampstands on the tables.

Solomon makes 100 small gold bowls. People use these bowls to hold the blood from the animals they sacrifice, and then people sprinkle the blood on the altar.

Solomon makes walls for the inner courtyard where only priests could go. Solomon also makes walls and a door for the larger courtyard where any person could go. Solomon covers the doors to the courtyards with bronze. Solomon places the Sea outside the temple on the southeast side.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Solomon places each object in a specific location. Look at a diagram that shows where Solomon placed the objects. How will you describe the location of each object based on the diagram? Pause this audio here.

Cultures have different ways to describe directions like north, south, east, and west. You will remember that the sun rises in the east. How will you describe the different directions for your culture? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Hiram—even though the storyteller does not mention Hiram’s name in this passage, we know Hiram is the main worker
- Workers who help Hiram
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Solomon tells Hiram to make two bronze pillars for the front of the temple. On top of each pillar, Solomon puts a capital, bronze chains, and bronze images of pomegranates for decoration. Solomon places one pillar on the south side of the temple entrance, and Solomon names that pillar Jakin. Solomon places the other pillar on the north side of the entrance, and Solomon names that pillar Boaz.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hiram, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that I can use my bronze-working skills to help Solomon make Yahweh’s temple beautiful; or
- I feel honored because I get to work on Yahweh’s temple.

Continue the drama.

Solomon builds a bronze altar, and Solomon makes the large, round bronze basin called the Sea. The Sea measures 10 cubits rim to rim and 5 cubits high. People use a string that is 30 cubits long to measure around the Sea. Solomon decorates the Sea under its rim with two rows of figures that look like bulls. Solomon uses 10 bulls for every cubit around the Sea. Solomon makes the Sea and the decorative figures at the same time from the same mold.

Solomon places the Sea on 12 larger figures that look like bulls. The bulls face outward, three in each direction, and the sea sits on their backs. The Sea measures a handbreadth thick, and its rim curves out like the rim of a cup or the petal of a lily. The Sea can hold about 3,000 baths of water.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel pleased to see my people spend so much time and resources to honor me; or
- I feel happy because I know that, even though I could make my own house, Solomon and my people work hard to honor me by building this beautiful temple for me to live in.

Continue the drama.

Solomon makes 10 smaller wash basins for the outside of the temple. Solomon places 5 basins on the south side and 5 basins on the north side of the temple. People use these basins to wash the things they use to offer burnt offerings, but priests use the Sea to wash their hands and feet.

Next, Solomon makes 10 lampstands and 10 tables from gold. Solomon places these objects inside the main hall of the temple, 5 of each on the south side and 5 of each on the north side. Solomon also makes 100 gold bowls for sprinkling blood.

Solomon builds the walls of the inner courtyard that only priests can use. Solomon also builds walls and doors for the larger outer courtyard, where any person can enter. Solomon covers the courtyard doors with bronze. Solomon places the Sea outside the temple on the southeast corner.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel hopeful that Yahweh will like all the objects we make for Yahweh’s temple; or
- I feel confident that Yahweh’s temple will be beautiful and will use the best materials available.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Stop here and listen: If you have already translated 1 Kings 7:13–39, which contains the same information, listen to your translation of that passage as a group. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes two bronze metal pillars for the front entrance of the **temple**. People usually make tall vertical structures called “pillars” out of metal, wood, or stone. Pillars may help to support a building, or people may use pillars as decoration. Israelites worship Yahweh in the temple. Use the same word or phrase for temple as you have used in previous passages. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a **pillar**. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for pillar. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the pillars 35 cubits long. People use cubits to measure length, and a cubit measures about 50 centimeters. Use the same word or phrase for **cubit** as you used in previous passages. For more information on cubit, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon places a capital on top of each pillar. The word capital is special language that refers to an object that Solomon uses to decorate the top of each pillar. Because these pillars probably do not support the roof of the temple, the capitals sit on the top of each pillar.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **capital**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes chains and images of pomegranates to decorate the capitals on the pillars. People probably weave bronze metal together to make chains that look like braids. Pomegranates are reddish fruits about the same size as a human’s fist. People probably make images of these pomegranates out of bronze metal.

Stop here and look at a picture of **chains** and a **pomegranate**. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for chain and pomegranate. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes an **altar** out of **bronze**. An altar is a place where people make sacrifices to Yahweh. An altar is like a table or platform where people put sacrifices, and people often burn these sacrifices on the altar. Bronze is a metal that people make by combining copper and tin. Use the same word or phrase for altar and bronze as you used in previous passages. For more information on altar and bronze, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon makes the Sea out of metal and places decorations that may look like bulls just below the rim. A bull is a male ox.

Stop here and look at a picture of a **bull** as a group. If you choose to use the interpretation that says these are bulls, discuss what word or phrase you will use for bull. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the Sea about one handbreadth thick. People use a handbreadth, which measures about 4 fingers or 8 centimeters, to measure how thick something is.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **handbreadth**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the rim of the Sea curve outward like the rim of a cup or the petals on a lily. A lily is a large red or white flower with petals that curve out away from its center.

Stop here and look at a picture of a **lily**. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for lily. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the Sea large enough to hold 3,000 **baths**. We do not know exactly how much a bath might be, but the Sea probably holds between 40,000 and 80,000 liters of water. Baths measure the volume of liquid. Use the same word or phrase for bath as you used in previous passages.

Solomon makes 10 wash basins to place outside the temple. People use the wash basins to clean the things people use to make **burnt offerings**. A burnt offering is a form of sacrifice that people bring to Yahweh. Look up burnt offering in the master Glossary for more information. Use the same word that you have used in previous passages.

Although people use the wash basins to clean the things for burnt offerings, priests use the Sea to wash themselves. Priests are people who work in the temple of Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **priest**. Look up priest in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes 10 lampstands and 100 small bowls out of **gold**. Gold is a precious yellow metal. Use the same word or phrase for gold as you have used in previous passages.

People light wicks on lampstands to use as a source of light.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **lampstand**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 28:9–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 28:9–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, we heard how King Ahaz of Judah, the southern kingdom, did not follow Yahweh but instead worshipped foreign gods. So Yahweh allowed Judah's enemies, including Israel, the northern kingdom, to defeat Judah. The soldiers of Israel killed many of Judah's soldiers. Israel's army also brought 200,000 people, including women and children, from Judah back to the city of Samaria as prisoners. In this story, we will now hear what Yahweh tells the people of Israel to do with those prisoners.

The story begins when one of Yahweh's prophets, Oded, comes out of the city of Samaria to speak to the army of Israel. The Israelite army has just returned from Judah with the prisoners. You will remember that Samaria is the capital city of the northern kingdom of Israel.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows the southern kingdom of Judah and the northern kingdom of Israel. Find the city of Samaria on the map. Pause this audio here.

Oded tells the army that Yahweh was angry with Judah, and that is why Yahweh allowed the army of Israel to defeat Judah. But now, Yahweh is angry with Israel because Israel's soldiers killed Judah's people in a very angry and cruel way.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about some soldiers who fought a battle in a very angry and cruel way. What did those soldiers do that was different from how people normally expect soldiers to behave in battle? Pause this audio here.

Oded also says that the soldiers now plan to make all of these people from Judah Israel's slaves. You will remember that in the law that Yahweh gave to Moses, in the book of Leviticus, Yahweh allowed an Israelite to work as a servant to another Israelite for a time to pay off a debt. But Yahweh said the people were never to make another Israelite a slave. So it would be very wrong for the soldiers to do this.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do people think about slavery in your culture? If people take slaves, how do those people treat those slaves? Which types of people are you allowed to take slaves from? Would you ever take slaves from people who are related to you? Pause this audio here.

Oded also reminds the soldiers that although the people of Judah sinned, the people of Israel have sinned too. You will remember the story from earlier in this book and in 1 Kings of how the 10 northern tribes first formed their own kingdom, with Jeroboam as king. At that time, King Jeroboam created idols for the people to worship so that the people would not have to go to Jerusalem in Judah to worship at Yahweh's temple. So Israel has done the same kinds of sinful things that Judah has done.

Oded warns the soldiers that Yahweh is very angry with Israel, just as Yahweh was angry with Judah. Oded says the soldiers must release these people and let the people go back home to Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when an army wins a battle against another army, how do people explain why those people were able to win? Pause this audio here.

Four of Israel's leaders now speak to the soldiers and repeat the same warning Oded just gave. The leaders say that the soldiers cannot bring these prisoners to Samaria. The leaders say that the people of Israel are already very guilty of sin against Yahweh and that Yahweh is very angry.

So the soldiers let the prisoners go free. The soldiers also give everything the soldiers took during the battle to the leaders. Then, from those things, the leaders give the people from Judah clothing to cover their bodies and sandals to put on their feet. The leaders also give the people food and drink and take care of the people's wounds from the battle. The leaders give anyone who is unable to walk a donkey to ride. Then the leaders take all of the people back to the city of Jericho in Judah so the people can be with their relatives. People call Jericho the city of palm trees.

Stop here as a group and again look at the map of Israel that shows the southern kingdom of Judah and the northern kingdom of Israel. Find Jericho on the map. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at pictures of sandals, a donkey, and palm trees. Pause this audio here.

Finally, the leaders return to Samaria, their home in the kingdom of Israel.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9-15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Oded, one of Yahweh's prophets, comes out of the city of Samaria to speak to the army of Israel as the army returns with prisoners from Judah. Oded says that Yahweh let Israel defeat Judah because Yahweh was angry with Judah. But Israel has sinned too, so Yahweh will punish Israel if they keep these people from Judah as prisoners.

In the second scene: Four of Israel's leaders speak to Israel's army. The leaders repeat Oded's warning.

In the third scene: Israel's army lets Judah's people go free.

In the fourth scene: Israel's leaders give the people from Judah clothes and sandals to wear and food and drink. The leaders also take care of the people's battle wounds. Then the leaders take all of the people back home to Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Oded, Yahweh's prophet
- Yahweh
- Soldiers from the northern kingdom of Israel
- All the people of the southern kingdom of Judah
- The prisoners from Judah
- And four leaders from the northern kingdom: Azariah, Jehohanan's son; Berekiah, Meshillemoth's son; Jehizkiah, Shallum's son; and Amasa, Hadlai's son

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

You will remember that in the last story, the army of Israel, the northern kingdom, killed many people in Judah during a battle. Then the army brought many prisoners back to the city of Samaria, in the northern kingdom.

Stop here as a group and again find the city of Samaria on the map of Judah and Israel, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Now, as the first scene begins, the storyteller explains that one of Yahweh's prophets, Oded, lives in Samaria. You will remember that a prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Oded comes out of the city to meet the army as the army approaches Samaria. Then Oded speaks to the army. In the original language, Oded begins with a word that means "Look!" or "Pay attention!" Then Oded tells the army why Israel was able to defeat Judah in the battle. Oded says that Yahweh, the God of the people's ancestors, was angry with Judah. You will remember that although Yahweh has always been the Israelites' God, the people have worshiped other gods instead of Yahweh for a long time. So Oded probably calls Yahweh the God of the Israelites to remind the people that Yahweh is the God their ancestors worshiped.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The storyteller refers to Yahweh as the God of the people's ancestors. How do you talk about who your ancestors worshiped, whether it was God or the local gods or spirits? Pause this audio here.

Oded says that it was because Yahweh was angry with Judah that Yahweh gave Judah into Israel's hand. This is special language that means that Yahweh gave the army of Israel power and control over Judah. But although Yahweh allowed this to happen, Israel's army killed the army of Judah in a very angry and cruel way, without mercy. Oded says this reached up to heaven, which is special language that means that God, who is in heaven, saw what the army did.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about soldiers who fight in a way that is very cruel or who show no mercy even when they win the battle? If needed, think about the story you told in step two and how you described the soldiers in your story. Pause this audio here.

Now, Oded says that the army plans to make these people of Judah and Jerusalem, both male and female, slaves to the people of the northern kingdom of Israel. You will remember that Judah is one of the tribes of Israel, but Judah is also the name of the southern kingdom. Jerusalem is the capital city of Judah. Jerusalem was also the capital city of all of Israel before the people divided into two different kingdoms. Jerusalem is where Solomon built Yahweh's temple. Oded asks the army a question that Oded does not expect anyone to answer. Oded asks the men, "But are you not also guilty of sins against Yahweh your God?" Oded asks this question to show the army that just like Yahweh punished Judah, Yahweh will also punish Israel if the army disobeys Yahweh and takes these people as slaves.

Oded tells the army to hear Oded, which means to pay attention to Oded. Oded says to send all of these prisoners back home. Oded reminds the army that these people are the men's relatives. You will remember from a previous story that most of the people who live in the southern kingdom are from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin, but some people from other Israelite tribes also live in Judah. Either way, all of these people come from the same 12 tribes of Israel, and all of the people are related. Oded says the army must send all of the people back home because Yahweh's wrath or burning anger is on the army, which means that Yahweh feels very angry with the army and plans to punish the people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you talk about someone who feels very, very angry? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller says that some chiefs or leaders of Ephraim confront the soldiers. You will remember that Ephraim is one of the tribes that live in the northern kingdom, but here the storyteller uses Ephraim to mean the entire northern kingdom. The storyteller says these leaders are Azariah, Jehohanan's son; Berekiah, Meshillemoth's son; Jehizkiah, Shallum's son; and Amasa, Hadlai's son. These four leaders speak to the army and repeat the same warning that Oded just gave. The leaders say that the army must not bring the prisoners into the city, because if they do, it will make the people's sin and guilt before Yahweh even worse than it already is. The leaders say that the people are already very guilty and that Yahweh's wrath, or anger, is very great toward the people of the northern kingdom.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about people who deserve punishment because of the wrong things those people have done? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the soldiers release the prisoners and all the things the soldiers took during the battle. The soldiers do this in front of the leaders and all of the other people who have gathered together.

In the fourth scene, the storyteller says that the men whom people mentioned by name rise up and take the prisoners. We are not sure what the storyteller means by “the men whom people mentioned by name.” The storyteller may use this phrase to refer to the four leaders, Azariah, Berekiah, Jehizkiah, and Amasa. Or the storyteller may mean that the leaders specifically choose other men to help the prisoners. Also, “rose up” does not mean that the men were first lying down. This is special language that means the men take action. First, the men give the prisoners clothes and sandals to wear from the spoils, or all the things the army took from Judah during the battle. The men also give the people food and drink because the people are probably very hungry and thirsty after the battle and the journey to Samaria. The men also anoint the people. This means the men put olive oil on people’s wounds. Many people were probably injured in the battle, and at this time, people often used oil from olives, a type of fruit, to put on wounds as medicine.

Then the men carried the feeble people on donkeys. This means that people who were weak or injured and could not walk rode on donkeys, which are large animals with four legs. The men took all of the people, whom the storyteller reminds us are kinfolk or relatives of the men, to Jericho, which people call “the city of palm trees.”

Stop here as a group and again find the city of Jericho on the map of Judah and Israel, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look again at pictures of sandals, a donkey, and palm trees, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Finally, the men returned home to Samaria in the northern kingdom of Israel.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9-15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Oded, Yahweh’s prophet
- Yahweh
- Soldiers from the northern kingdom of Israel
- All the people of the southern kingdom of Judah
- The prisoners from Judah
- And four leaders from the northern kingdom: Azariah, Jehohanan’s son; Berekiah, Meshillemoth’s son; Jehizkiah, Shallum’s son; and Amasa, Hadlai’s son

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Oded is one of Yahweh's prophets, and Oded lives in Samaria. Oded goes out to meet Israel's army as they return to Samaria. Oded says to the army, "Yahweh, the God of your ancestors, was angry with Judah. That is why Yahweh let you defeat Judah. But you killed the people with so much violence that even God in heaven is shocked. And now you want to make these people from Judah and Jerusalem your slaves. But you have sinned too, and you are guilty before Yahweh your God. Now listen to me! You have the same ancestors as these people you have captured. So free these people and let them go home. Otherwise, Yahweh will be very angry and will punish you."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Israel's army, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We must be a very good army, because we completely defeated Judah's army; or
- The gods that we worship must be very pleased with us, because we won a great victory today! or
- We will show these people from Judah how strong we are. We will take everything Judah's people have and make them our slaves.

Ask the people playing the prisoners from Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel very scared. These men killed many of our families in a brutal way, and we do not know what these men will do to us now; or
- Even though we often fight with our relatives, we did not expect these men to treat us this badly.

Ask the person playing Oded, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- These soldiers think they won this battle by their own strength, but it was Yahweh who let them win; or
- Yahweh was angry with Judah because they served other gods, but the northern kingdom is guilty of the same sins; or
- These people have served other gods for so long that I have to remind them that Yahweh is their God; or
- These soldiers think that they are successful today, but they do not realize that God is about to punish them.

Continue the drama.

Now, four of the leaders of the northern kingdom of Israel speak to the army and tell the army that the army is doing wrong. These leaders are Azariah, son of Jehohanan; Berekiah, son of Meshillemoth; Jehizkiah, son of Shallum; and Amasa, son of Hadlai. These men tell the army, "Do not bring these prisoners here. If you do that, Yahweh will consider us guilty of sin. You are making our sins and faults even greater. We are already very guilty, and Yahweh is very angry with us."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the soldiers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel surprised. We thought our leaders would be happy that we won the battle and that we brought back all of these good things and these people to be our slaves; or
- We feel shame. We were very strong and powerful in battle, but Oded and our leaders have made us look foolish; or
- We feel afraid. We thought the gods were happy with us, but now our ancestors' God, Yahweh, might punish us!

Ask the people playing the four leaders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel afraid that Yahweh will punish our people; or
- All of this wealth and power that the army has taken will do us no good if Yahweh punishes us.

Continue the drama.

So, in front of the leaders and all of the people, the soldiers let all of the prisoners go free, and the soldiers laid down all of the things they had taken during the battle.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing soldiers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We fought very hard to win, and we feel like we deserve to keep these things, but we do not want to receive punishment; or
- I think Oded was right. These people are our relatives, and we should not have been so harsh with these people.

Continue the drama.

The leaders choose some men to help the people from Judah. Out of all of the things the soldiers brought back from battle, the men take clothes and give them to the people from Judah who are naked. The men also give people sandals to put on their feet. The men give people food and drink, and the men put oil on people’s wounds. The men put people who are weak on donkeys, and then the men bring all of these people, who are the men’s relatives, back to Jericho, the city of the palms.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people from Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are surprised that the soldiers and the leaders listened to Oded; or
- We are so happy that we do not have to be slaves, and that we can go home.

Continue the drama.

Then the men from Israel go back home to the city of Samaria.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9-15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Oded, a **prophet** of **Yahweh**, comes out to meet the army when the army comes back to **Samaria**. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Yahweh is God’s personal name. Use the same words or phrases for prophet, Samaria, and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet, Samaria, and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Oded reminds the soldiers that Yahweh is the **God** of their **fathers**. In the Bible, “God” refers to God who created everything. This is the general word for God. Here, the word “fathers” means ancestors. Use the same words or phrases for God and fathers as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Oded says that the Israel army killed the Judah army in a rage that reached up to **heaven**. This is special language that means that God in heaven saw what the army did. Heaven refers to the place where God lives with his angels. Use the same word or phrase for heaven as you used in previous passages. For more information on heaven, refer to the Master Glossary.

Oded says the army now plans to make these people slaves, or to force these people to serve the Israelites. A slave is the property of a master. The master can sell the slave to someone else, just as he can sell his other property. A slave works without pay and is not free to leave their master. Some masters treated slaves cruelly. The storyteller just says that the Israelites want to make the people they captured from Judah serve them forcefully. You may need to say that the Israelites wanted to make the captives from Judah their slaves. If so, translate slave in the same way you have previously, and refer to **slave** in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use to show that the soldiers wanted to force the people from Judah to serve the Israelites. Pause this audio here.

Oded reminds the army that these people are their **brothers**, which means relatives. Use the same word or phrase for brothers or relatives as you used in previous passages.

Some chiefs or leaders of **Ephraim** speak to the army. Ephraim is one of the tribes of Israel, but here Ephraim refers to the whole northern kingdom of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for Ephraim as you used in previous passages.

The leaders say that the people's **sins** and **guilt** are very great. Sin is rebellion against God. Guilt means that someone has done something wrong and deserves punishment. Use the same words or phrases for sins and guilt as you used in previous passages. For more information on sin and guilt, refer to the Master Glossary.

So the soldiers let go of the prisoners and the **plunder** in the presence of the **princes**, or high officials, and all of the **assembly**. Plunder means all of the valuable things that an army takes from the enemy in battle. "Princes" is another word for important leaders, and "assembly" means a large group of people who gather together for a special purpose. Use the same words or phrases for plunder, princes, and assembly as you used in previous passages.

The leaders give the people from Judah clothing, sandals, and food and drink from the plunder the army took during the battle. Sandals are a type of footwear with a leather sole that people tie to the bottom of their foot with leather thongs or straps.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sandals**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The leaders anoint the people. To anoint someone means to pour sweet-smelling oil over that person. Many times in the Bible, to anoint meant to pour oil over a person or object to show that the person or thing was holy, or dedicated to God. But here, to anoint means to put oil on people's wounds to help the wounds heal.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **anoint**. Look up anoint in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The men carry the feeble people on donkeys. To be feeble means to fall down from weakness or to be unable to walk. A donkey is a large animal with four legs that people in Israel often rode or used to carry heavy burdens.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **feeble** and **donkeys**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The leaders take the people back to Jericho, the "city of palm trees." These are date palm trees. Date palms are slow-growing, evergreen trees with arching gray-green fronds that can grow up to 10 feet long. This kind of palm tree grows a sweet fruit that people call dates.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "**city of palm trees**." If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Finally, the men return to Samaria in the northern kingdom of Israel.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 28:16–27

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, we learned that Yahweh was angry with the kingdom of Judah because the people had done evil and worshiped other gods. As punishment, Yahweh began to allow Judah's enemies, including the northern kingdom of Israel, to defeat Judah in battle. Now, in this story, we will learn how Judah's king, Ahaz, continues to reject Yahweh and turn to foreign gods for help, and how this hurts Ahaz even more.

As the story begins, we learn that Judah's enemies have continued to attack and defeat Judah, so King Ahaz sends someone to take a message to the king of Assyria to ask for help. We know this is Tiglath Pileser III, who was king of Assyria from 744 B.C. to 727 B.C. Assyria was a country in northern Mesopotamia, the area that today is northern Iran.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows Assyria and Judah. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller specifically mentions how the Edomites had attacked Judah and carried away prisoners, and how the Philistines had raided or attacked some of Judah's cities in the lower hills to the west side of Judah and also to the south of Judah. You will remember that the Edomites lived in the land south of Judah, and the Philistines lived in the land west of Judah along the Mediterranean Sea. The storyteller says that the Philistines had taken control of the cities of Beth Shemesh, Aijalon, Gederot, Soco, Timnah, and Gimzo and also the smaller villages that surrounded those cities.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Judah that also shows Edom and Philistia. Find each of these cities on the map. Pause this audio here.

Now we learn why these countries were able to defeat Judah. The storyteller says that Yahweh humbled the king of Judah, King Ahaz, because the king turned away from Yahweh and encouraged the people to do wicked things. And so, when King Ahaz sends word to the king of Assyria, Tiglath-Pileser, to ask for help, Tiglath-Pileser oppresses Ahaz instead of helping. Ahaz takes many expensive things from Yahweh's temple, from Ahaz's own

house, and even from the leaders who work for King Ahaz, and gives these things to Tiglath-Pileser as payment for his help, but this does not help Ahaz.

When all of these bad things happened, King Ahaz should have asked Yahweh for help, but instead, Ahaz asked the gods of Judah's enemies for help. Ahaz offered sacrifices to the gods that people worshiped in Damascus, the capital city of Aram, or Syria. Ahaz said that if those gods had helped Ahaz's enemies, then Ahaz would ask those gods to help Ahaz, too. But the storyteller says that those gods ruined Ahaz and Judah rather than helping.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell about a time someone tried to fix a bad choice they had made, but that person just made it worse. Pause this audio here.

Ahaz took all of the valuable things out of God's temple and destroyed those things. Ahaz also shut the doors of Yahweh's temple so that no one could go into the temple anymore. Instead, Ahaz had people build altars where people could worship foreign gods at the corner of every street in Jerusalem. And in every town in Judah, Ahaz had people build places to sacrifice to foreign gods there, too. All of these things made Yahweh, the God that Ahaz's ancestors worshiped, very angry.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Where do people worship God, or local spirits or gods, in your community? What are the right ways to worship those local spirits or gods? What happens if someone decides to worship another way? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller finishes his story by reminding us that people wrote other important stories about King Ahaz in the book, or scroll, about the kings of Judah and Israel. You will remember that this book is not in the Bible and no longer exists. The storyteller also says that when Ahaz died, people buried Ahaz in Jerusalem, but the people did not put Ahaz's body in the tomb of the kings of Israel. The storyteller probably says this to show that people did not honor Ahaz because Ahaz was wicked and disobeyed Yahweh. However, this is different than what we hear in 2 Kings 16, where that storyteller says that people buried Ahaz with his ancestors. We are not sure why these are different, but it may mean that the people buried Ahaz near his ancestors, but not in the royal tomb. Finally, after Ahaz died, Ahaz's son Hezekiah became the next king.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: The Edomites and Philistines have once again attacked and defeated Judah, so King Ahaz asks the king of Assyria to help protect Judah.

In the second scene: The storyteller reminds us that Yahweh allowed these enemies to defeat Judah because King Ahaz had turned away from Yahweh and caused the people to sin.

In the third scene: Instead of protecting Judah, Assyria causes trouble, even though Ahaz gives the king of Assyria expensive things from Yahweh's temple as payment.

In the fourth scene: King Ahaz sacrifices to the gods of his enemy, so that those gods will help Ahaz. But instead, those gods destroy Ahaz.

In the fifth scene: Ahaz destroys the objects in Yahweh's temple and shuts the doors to the temple so no one will worship there. Instead, Ahaz makes sacred places where people can worship foreign gods. All of these actions make Yahweh very angry.

In the sixth scene: The storyteller tells how King Ahaz dies and how Ahaz's son Hezekiah becomes the next king.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahaz of Judah
- Edomite army

- Prisoners from Judah
- Philistine army
- People who live in and near Judah's cities that the Philistines capture
- King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria and his army, although the storyteller does not mention the army
- Yahweh
- Foreign gods
- And Hezekiah, Ahaz's son

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the storyteller begins by saying that at that time, King Ahaz sent to the king of Assyria for help. Here, the phrase “at that time” does not refer to the same time as the last story, when Syria and the king of Israel attacked Judah. Instead, it refers to a later time when Edom and Philistia attacked. Also, although the storyteller only says Ahaz “sent word,” we know that this means the king sent someone to take a message from Ahaz to the king of Assyria. The storyteller will say later in the story that this is King Tiglath-Pileser.

Stop here as a group and again look at a map that shows Assyria and Judah, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about when one person sends another person to carry a message to a third person who is far away? How will you translate the way King Ahaz sends this message here? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that King Ahaz sent this message because the Edomites had again invaded Judah and taken people away as captives or prisoners. Also, the Philistines had attacked cities in the Shephelah and the Negev of Judah. The Shephelah refers to the land in Judah where the hills are not very high. The Shephelah is west of the hill country of Judah but east of the Mediterranean seacoast. The Shephelah is south of the Aijalon Valley in an area about 65 kilometers long and 20 kilometers wide. The Negev refers to the southern part of Judah, where the land is very dry, or like a desert.

Stop here as a group and look at pictures of the Shephelah and the Negev wilderness. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines took control of Beth Shemesh. There are four different cities in the Old Testament called Beth Shemesh, but most people believe that this Beth Shemesh was located on the northwest border of Judah, about 24 kilometers west of Jerusalem. The Philistines also took Aijalon, which people believe was about 20 kilometers northwest of Jerusalem, and Gederot, which people believe was [about 18 kilometers southwest of Lod on the Ramle-Al Mughar road. The Philistines took Soco with its villages.} There are three different cities in the Old Testament called Soco, but this is likely the Soco located in the Shephelah, about 30 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem. The Philistines took Timnah with its villages. Timnah was located on the northern border of Judah, about 6.5 kilometers north of Beth Shemesh. And finally, the Philistines took Gimzo, which was located in the lowland region near the Philistine plain, about 5 kilometers southeast of Lod off the Jerusalem road in the Aijalon Valley. The storyteller says that the Philistines settled in these cities and the villages around these cities, which means to live in those places permanently.

Stop here as a group and again look at a map of Judah that shows the likely location of each of these cities. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller says that Yahweh humbled Judah because Ahaz, king of Israel, had encouraged the people to do wicked things, and because Ahaz himself had been unfaithful to Yahweh. You will remember that the nation of Israel was divided into two different kingdoms at this time. One of these kingdoms was the northern kingdom, which people called Israel. The other kingdom was the southern kingdom, which people called Judah. We know that Ahaz was the king of the southern kingdom of Judah, but the storyteller may call Ahaz the “king of Israel” to remind us that Ahaz is acting just as badly as the people of the northern kingdom, who worshiped other gods.

In the third scene, because Ahaz has done these wicked things, when Ahaz asks King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria for help, Tiglath-Pileser instead comes against Ahaz, which means he attacks Ahaz instead of helping. In the original language, we are not sure if the storyteller says that Tiglath-Pileser did not make Ahaz strong by helping Ahaz, or if the storyteller says that Tiglath-Pileser could not overpower Ahaz or defeat him. Either way, we understand that Tiglath-Pileser made things worse for Ahaz and not better.

The storyteller says that Ahaz took or stole things from Yahweh's house, the temple. Ahaz also took things from his own palace, the house where Ahaz lived as the king. And Ahaz also took things from the "princes" or leaders of Judah who worked for the king. Ahaz then gave all of these expensive things to Tiglath-Pileser as a way to pay for Assyria's help, but the storyteller says this did not help Ahaz. In other words, Tiglath-Pileser did not help, even though Ahaz paid Tiglath-Pileser to help.

In the fourth scene, the storyteller says that when Ahaz is distressed, or when all these bad things happen, Ahaz acts even more unfaithfully to Yahweh. Ahaz makes sacrifices to the gods of Damascus that defeated Ahaz. Remember that Damascus is the capital city of Syria, so these are the gods that the Syrians worship. And Ahaz said, "Because the gods of the kings of Syria helped those kings, I will sacrifice to those gods so that those gods may help me too." Here, the storyteller may mean that Ahaz said this out loud to himself, or it may mean that Ahaz simply thought this thing. Either way, the storyteller tells us this so we will know why Ahaz made sacrifices to these other gods. However, the storyteller says these gods ruined Ahaz and all of Israel, which means that the gods only made things worse, not better. When the storyteller says Israel here, we do not know if he refers to Judah, the kingdom where Ahaz rules, or to the northern kingdom, where people also worshiped foreign gods.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a person who does something that people would not expect. Then tell people what that person thought that caused the person to act that way. Pay attention to the way you explain this. Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, the storyteller says that Ahaz gathered together the vessels of the house of God and cut the vessels into pieces. You will remember that the house of God means Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem. The "vessels" refer to the various holy items in the temple that the priests used to worship Yahweh. Apparently, Ahaz destroys these things to prevent people from worshiping Yahweh. Then Ahaz closes the doors to the temple. This probably means that Ahaz locks the doors so that no one can enter the temple to worship Yahweh anymore. Instead, Ahaz makes altars in every corner in Jerusalem. This probably means that Ahaz commands people to build these altars, or places for people to worship these gods, in many places around the city of Jerusalem. Also, in every city of Judah, Ahaz makes high places to burn incense to other gods. High places probably refers to places on hills where people would make special shrines to foreign gods. The storyteller says that all of these things provoked Yahweh, the God of Ahaz's ancestors, to anger. This means that Yahweh felt very angry that Ahaz did all of this.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone in your community did something that people thought angered God or the local gods or spirits. What did that person do? How did people talk about those things the person did? How did people feel about those actions? Pause this audio here.

In the last scene, the storyteller uses the same kind of formal talk he used to describe other kings. First, the storyteller says that everything that happened when Ahaz was king, and everything Ahaz did, is in the scroll or book of the kings of Judah and Israel. You will remember that a scroll is a type of ancient book where people wrote everything on one very long piece of paper and then rolled that paper around a stick. The storyteller says that Ahaz "slept with his fathers." This is a nice way to say that Ahaz died, just as Ahaz's ancestors before Ahaz did. People buried Ahaz in the city of Jerusalem, but people did not place Ahaz's body in the tombs of the kings of Israel. And finally, Hezekiah, Ahaz's son, succeeded Ahaz as king. This means that Hezekiah became the next king after Ahaz.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahaz of Judah
- Edomite army
- Prisoners from Judah

- Philistine army
- People who live in and near Judah's cities that the Philistines capture
- King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria and his army, although the storyteller does not mention the army
- Yahweh
- Foreign gods
- And Hezekiah, Ahaz's son

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Then King Ahaz sent people to King Tiglath-Pileser, the king of Assyria, to ask for help. Ahaz did this because the Edomites had again come and attacked Judah and taken people away as prisoners. And at the same time, the Philistines had raided the cities and towns in Judah's low hills and also the Negev. The Philistines captured and settled in Beth Shemesh, Aijalon, and Gederot, as well as Soco, Timnah, and Gimzo, along with the villages around those cities.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Ahaz, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I keep losing battles to my enemies. I need to do something to stop this! or
- Now we have even fewer people and cities to protect ourselves; or
- I am not sure if I can trust the Assyrians, but I know they have a strong army. Maybe I can pay the Assyrians to help us.

Continue the drama.

Because of the evil things King Ahaz did, Yahweh made the kingdom of Judah low. Ahaz had led his people to do evil things, and Ahaz himself disobeyed Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am the one who protects my people, but now my people worship other gods instead of me. These other gods cannot help the people! or
- I will stop protecting my people so that the people will see that these gods can do nothing for them; or
- Ahaz has rejected me, so now I will reject Ahaz.

Continue the drama.

King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria comes to Ahaz. But instead of helping, Tiglath-Pileser gives Ahaz even more trouble. Ahaz takes some of the things from Yahweh's temple, from Ahaz's palace, and from the officials of Judah, and Ahaz gives these expensive things to Tiglath-Pileser as payment. But this does not help Ahaz.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ahaz, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not want to give these expensive things away, but if it can help save my kingdom, it is worth it!

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I allowed these things to happen so Ahaz would remember to obey and worship me. But instead, Ahaz steals things from my temple to pay a human king to help.

Ask the person playing King Tiglath-Pileser, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- My army is bigger and stronger than Judah’s. I cannot completely defeat Judah in battle, but I will gladly take these expensive things from them.

Continue the drama.

King Ahaz disobeyed Yahweh even more when all of these bad things happened. Ahaz made sacrifices to the gods of Damascus, who had defeated Ahaz in battle, because Ahaz thought, “The gods of the kings of Aram have helped those kings, so I will also sacrifice to those gods. Then those gods will help me too.” But worshiping those gods ruined Ahaz and all the people of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the people of Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- Our enemies stole some of our people and cities. We must do something to protect ourselves! or
- If Yahweh allowed these bad things to happen, maybe other gods can help instead; or
- We will do whatever our king tells us to do.

Continue the drama.

King Ahaz gathered up and destroyed all of the sacred things from Yahweh’s temple. Ahaz shut and locked the doors of the temple so that no one could go in to worship Yahweh anymore. Then Ahaz set up altars at the corner of every street in Jerusalem, and Ahaz built sacred places to burn sacrifices to foreign gods in every town in Judah. This made Yahweh, the God that Ahaz’s ancestors worshiped, very angry.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Ahaz continues to disobey me and treat me with great disrespect; or
- Ahaz not only disobeys me and worships other gods, but Ahaz makes other people disobey me too; or
- I will punish Ahaz and the people of Judah for doing these things.

Continue the drama.

King Ahaz did many things while he was king, and people wrote about all of these things in the book “The History of the Kings of Judah and Israel.” Then Ahaz died, and people buried Ahaz with his ancestors. People buried Ahaz in Jerusalem, but the people did not bury Ahaz in the tombs of the kings of Israel. After Ahaz died, Ahaz’s son Hezekiah became the next king of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people of Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- The good kings of Judah in the past always worshiped Yahweh, but Ahaz changed all of that; or
- It seems like all of the changes Ahaz made in Judah made things worse for us, not better; or
- We need to show respect, but Ahaz was not a very good king. So we will bury Ahaz in Jerusalem, but not in the tombs where people buried the most important kings.

Ask the person playing Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- My father stopped people from worshiping Yahweh, our ancestors’ God; or
- My father thought these other gods would make us stronger, but worshiping those gods made everything worse; or
- I do not want to be like my father. My father did not leave a good legacy as king.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

As the story begins, **King** Ahaz sends a message to the king of Assyria to ask for help. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages. King is in the Master Glossary.

Assyria was a country in northern Mesopotamia, the area that today is northern Iran.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Assyria**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The **Edomites** had once again defeated Judah and carried away captives or prisoners. You will remember that the Edomites were the ancestors of Esau, Jacob's brother. Jacob, who God later named Israel, was the ancestor of the Israelites. Use the same word or phrase for Edomites as you used in previous passages.

The Philistines had also made raids and taken several **cities** in the **foothills** and the Negev wilderness. Translate cities the same as you have in previous passages. The foothills refer to the land in Judah where the hills are not very high. These foothills are west of the hill country of Judah but east of the Mediterranean seacoast. Use the same word or phrase for foothills as you used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look again at a picture of the foothills, if needed. Pause this audio here.

The Negev refers to the Negev wilderness, the southern part of Judah, where the land is very dry, or like a desert.

Stop here as a group and look again at a picture of the Negev wilderness, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **Negev wilderness**. If you use the word for wilderness, refer to wilderness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh **humbled** Judah. **Yahweh** is God's personal name, and to humble people means to make those people submit, to bring them low, or to make them lose face. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh and humbled as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh humbled Judah because King Ahaz had promoted wickedness or caused Judah to act sinfully. Wickedness means evil, or the opposite of good, and to sin means to rebel against God. But here, King Ahaz does not just do wicked or sinful things himself. Instead, Ahaz does wrong as the leader of Judah and causes other people to do sinful or wicked things.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **promoted wickedness** or **caused Judah to act sinfully**. Look up **wickedness** and **sin** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria **afflicted** Ahaz, even though Ahaz paid him with many things. To afflict means to oppress or restrict either physically or emotionally. This does not necessarily mean that the Assyrians made war with Judah, but it does mean that Tiglath-Pileser made things even harder for Ahaz. Use the same word or phrase for afflicted as you used in previous passages.

King Ahaz **sacrificed** to the **gods** of Damascus. When the Israelites would make a sacrifice to Yahweh, it either meant to kill an animal and then burn the animal on an altar, or to give a gift to Yahweh of food items, oil, or sweet-smelling spices. But here, King Ahaz instead makes sacrifices to the foreign gods of Judah's enemies. Use the same words or phrases for sacrifice and gods as you used in previous passages. For more information on gods and on the kinds of sacrifices that people made to Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahaz destroyed the **vessels** in Yahweh's **temple**. Vessels refer to the items the priests would use in the temple for worship. Use the same words or phrases for vessels and temple as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up temple in the Master Glossary.

Ahaz made **altars** all around Jerusalem. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God, but Ahaz made these altars to make offerings to foreign gods. Use the same word or phrase for altars as you used in previous passages. For more information on the kind of altar that people made to worship Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahaz also made **high places**. People from these other countries would often make the shrines or places where they worshiped their gods on naturally high places, like hills, so Ahaz did the same thing in Judah. Use the same word or phrase for high places as you used in previous passages.

People wrote about everything King Ahaz did in a **book** or **scroll** about the kings of Judah and Israel. You will remember that in that time, a book or “scroll” was usually a long piece of leather or paper that people wrote on and then rolled up around a stick. This way, people could easily carry or store the scroll until they wanted to read it. Use the same word or phrase for book or scroll as you used in previous passages, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information about scroll.

Ahaz **slept with his fathers**. Slept is a nice way to say that Ahaz died, and “fathers” means Ahaz’s ancestors. Use the same word or phrase for “slept with his fathers” as you used in previous passages.

The storyteller says that people did not bury Ahaz in the **tombs** of the kings. A tomb is a place where people bury a dead body. These were often caves or rooms that people would hollow out of rock to hide the body from view. Use the same word or phrase for tomb as you used in previous passages. For more information about tomb, refer to the Master Glossary.

Finally, after Ahaz died, Ahaz’s son Hezekiah **reigned** in Ahaz’s place. To reign means to rule or act with power as king. Use the same word or phrase for reign as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 29:1-17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 29:1-17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1-17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1-17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, we learned how King Ahaz served other gods and kings instead of Yahweh and caused the people of Judah to sin, too. These things made Yahweh very angry. When Ahaz died, people did not honor Ahaz by burying his body with the other kings in Jerusalem. Then Ahaz's son, Hezekiah, became the new king of Judah.

In this story, we learn more about King Hezekiah. Remember that 2 Kings 18:1-12 has similar information about Hezekiah.

Stop here as a group and listen to your translation of 2 Kings 18:1-12 if you have already translated that passage. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah was 25 years old when he became king, and Hezekiah was king for 29 years. Hezekiah lived in Jerusalem. Hezekiah's mother was Abijah, and Abijah's father was Zechariah. Many men in the Bible had the name Zechariah, so we are not sure which Zechariah this is. However, we know this is not the man who wrote the book of Zechariah in the Bible.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what are some common names that more than one person has? Tell a story about a time when someone talked about one person, but people thought that person talked about a different person who had the same name. Tell what happened because people misunderstood. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah does good things that please Yahweh. Shortly after Hezekiah becomes king, Hezekiah opens the doors of Yahweh's temple. Hezekiah also has people repair these doors. You will remember from the previous stories that it was Hezekiah's father, King Ahaz, who shut the temple doors so people could not come to worship Yahweh anymore. But now, Hezekiah begins to undo the evil things Ahaz did.

Hezekiah gathers the Levites and priests outside the temple. You will remember that the Israelites were 12 tribes. One tribe was the Levites, and the Levites who descended from Moses' brother Aaron were the priests. The priests were responsible for offering sacrifices to Yahweh on the people's behalf. The priests took care of the temple and taught the people how to worship God. The other Levites helped the priests.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, which people are responsible for religious duties? How do people get those responsibilities? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah tells the Levites and priests to make themselves holy and to make the temple holy. Hezekiah says the ancestors of Judah's people were unfaithful to Yahweh and did evil things. Those people closed the temple doors and stopped serving Yahweh. So Yahweh became very angry with all the people. Yahweh punished Judah's people. The surrounding nations were horrified and surprised when they saw how Yahweh punished Judah. The people of those other nations talked badly about the people of Judah. Hezekiah says that the Levites and priests know that these things are true because they saw them happen. The people of Judah's ancestors died in battle, and the people's sons, daughters, and wives became prisoners in other countries. All of these things happened because of the evil things the people of Judah did.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, how do people act toward a person when they believe that God is punishing that person? What do people say to each other about that person? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah has decided that the people of Judah must make a covenant or agreement with Yahweh that the people will once again serve Yahweh and only Yahweh. Hezekiah hopes that when the people of Judah do this, Yahweh will stop being angry at the people.

Hezekiah tells the Levites and priests that they must begin working at the temple because Yahweh chose these men to serve Yahweh and offer sacrifices. So the Levites prepare themselves to work in the temple. Here, the storyteller gives the name of each of the Levite men who serve as a leader of a family group. These leaders organize all the men in their groups, and together, all the men ritually cleanse themselves and the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a large group of people with many smaller groups who all needed to work together. Tell how each smaller group had its own leader and how the leaders worked together to organize all of the people. Pause this audio here.

You will remember that the law that Yahweh gave to Moses included detailed instructions for how to make people and things holy before Yahweh. In the law, Yahweh said that only the priests could go into the inner part of the temple, so here, it is the priests who cleanse these parts. The priests bring out everything that is unclean. We do not know what these things are, but these are probably things Ahaz brought into the temple to worship other gods. The men bring all these things to the Kidron Valley. The Kidron Valley was a place on the east side of Jerusalem where people buried dead bodies. You will remember that the law said dead bodies were unclean, so we are not surprised that the men take these unclean things to this unclean place. You may also remember from an earlier story in 2 Chronicles 15:16 how King Asa brought idols to this valley to destroy the idols with fire.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows Jerusalem and the Kidron Valley. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what makes a person or thing ceremonially unclean or unholy? How do people treat a person or thing that is unholy? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says the priests and Levites began purifying, or making the temple holy, on the first day of the month. It took eight days to purify the temple courtyards and another eight days to purify the temple itself. So the men finished the work on the 16th day of that same month.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1-17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller gives general information about Hezekiah's time as king. We also learn that Hezekiah does what Yahweh says is right, just as King David did.

In the second scene: Hezekiah opens the temple so people can go inside, and Hezekiah repairs the temple.

In the third scene: Hezekiah tells the Levites and priests to purify themselves and the temple. Hezekiah reminds the men of the evil things the people's ancestors did. Hezekiah says it is because people did these evil things that Yahweh became angry and Judah's people suffered and died. But Hezekiah says the people will make a covenant with Yahweh so that Yahweh will stop being angry with Judah.

In the fourth scene: Hezekiah tells the Levites and priests to begin serving Yahweh and to help the people worship Yahweh.

In the fifth scene: All the Levites and priests begin to do their priestly work again. The men purify themselves and the temple. The men follow all of Yahweh's instructions.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hezekiah, Judah's king
- Abijah, who is Zechariah's daughter and Hezekiah's mother
- Yahweh

- King David, Hezekiah's ancestor
- The Levites
- The priests, who are also Levites
- The people of Judah
- The people's ancestors
- And the leaders of the Levite clans

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the storyteller gives the same information about Hezekiah as the previous kings. We hear that Hezekiah was 25 years old when Hezekiah became king. Hezekiah reigned or was in power as king in Jerusalem for 29 years. Hezekiah's mother was Abijah, and Abijah was the daughter of Zechariah. We are not sure which Zechariah this was.

Hezekiah did what was right in Yahweh's eyes, just as Hezekiah's father, King David, had done. This is special language that means that Hezekiah did the things Yahweh approved of. David was Hezekiah's ancestor. You will remember that many times in the Bible, "father" means an ancestor, not a person's literal father.

In the second scene, we hear that in the first year Hezekiah reigned as king, in the first month, Hezekiah opened the doors of Yahweh's temple and repaired the doors. This could mean that Hezekiah became king sometime during one year, and then, when the next year began, Hezekiah opened the temple. Or, more likely, this means Hezekiah began to reign in the first month of the year and immediately opened the temple. You will remember that for the Israelites, each year began at the time of year we call mid-March. So the storyteller shows that Hezekiah began to care for Yahweh's temple very soon after Hezekiah became king. You will remember that when the storyteller says Hezekiah repaired the temple doors, this probably means that Hezekiah told his workers to repair the doors, not that Hezekiah did the work himself.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you talk about when Hezekiah began to work on the temple in your translation? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, Hezekiah gathers the priests and Levites in the open place on the east. We are not sure what this place is, but we know it is east of the temple. This may refer to a place near one of the eastern gates of Jerusalem or perhaps the eastern courtyard in front of the temple, which faced east. We also do not know how Hezekiah gathers the men together. It may be that Hezekiah tells some of his workers to travel around and tell all of the priests and Levites to come to the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you talk about the place where Hezekiah gathers the men? You should translate this so it does not say an exact location, just like the storyteller does not say the exact location. For example, you might say something like, "the open place east of the temple" or "the gathering place east of the temple." Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah speaks to this large group of men. First, Hezekiah tells the Levites that they must pay attention to what Hezekiah says. You will remember that priests are a special kind of Levite, so when Hezekiah says "Levites," Hezekiah means all of the men, including the priests. Hezekiah tells the men to consecrate themselves, or to make themselves holy. Hezekiah also tells the men to consecrate the temple. Hezekiah calls Yahweh "the God of your fathers." Again, "fathers" means ancestors. Hezekiah probably says this to remind the Levites that although the people of Judah have been worshiping other nations' gods, Yahweh has always been the Israelites' God, and this is Yahweh's temple.

Hezekiah says the men must carry the dirty things out of the Holy Place. Hezekiah is not saying there is literally garbage or dirt in the temple. Hezekiah means the men must remove the idols and other unholy things from the temple. The sanctuary, or Holy Place, refers to the middle part of the temple, not the Most Holy Place, where only the high priest could enter once a year.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you talk about things that are ceremonially unclean, or unfit for people to use in worship? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah says the men's fathers were unfaithful. Again, "fathers" means ancestors, so Hezekiah refers to the way the previous generations of people worshipped other gods instead of Yahweh. The people did what was evil in Yahweh's sight. This is special language that means the people did what Yahweh said was very wrong.

Again, Hezekiah calls Yahweh the people's God. But Hezekiah says the people have left Yahweh, have turned their faces from where Yahweh lives, and have turned their backs. These are three similar ways to say the same idea. It seems Hezekiah wants the people to remember that Yahweh did not leave the people, but the people left Yahweh. Yahweh's presence is at the temple, but the people quit going to the temple. Instead, the people worshipped idols. Literally, when people quit going to the temple to worship Yahweh, the people no longer faced toward the temple. However, Hezekiah also uses this as a symbol to show how the people's relationship to Yahweh changed. When the people worshipped idols instead of Yahweh, the people no longer knew Yahweh, like a person who walks away from another person so that only their back faces that person.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Mark out an area on the ground to represent a person's house. Choose one person from your group to stand in that house. Next, have some people from your group come to that house to visit the person and become friends. Now, choose another person from your group and have that person stand some distance away from the house. Have the people who had been visiting the person at the house leave that person and instead go visit the new person. Pay attention to how the people walk away from the house and how they stand with their backs facing the house. Pause this audio here.

The people's ancestors also shut the doors of the vestibule or porch. This was the open area right in front of the doors that opened into the temple. You will remember that in the last story, we learned how Hezekiah's father, King Ahaz, shut these doors so people could not go into the temple.

The people's ancestors also put out the lamps and no longer burned incense or offered burnt offerings in the sanctuary, or Holy Place, to Israel's God. You will remember in the books of Exodus and Leviticus how Yahweh instructed the priests to always keep these lamps burning in the temple. Yahweh had also given the priests the responsibility to burn incense and make burnt offerings to Yahweh on behalf of the people. The Holy Place refers to the whole temple area, not just a specific part of the temple. And Israel refers specifically to the kingdom of Judah. You will remember that at this time, the nation of Israel was divided into two kingdoms: the kingdom that people called Judah in the south, and the kingdom that people called Israel in the north. But both kingdoms were part of the nation of Israel.

Stop here as a group and tell a story about two separate communities that were the same people group but did not get along with each other. How did the people talk about each other? Pause this audio here.

Because of the wrong things people did, Yahweh became very, very angry at the people of Judah and Jerusalem. Yahweh made people from other nations feel horrified and surprised when they saw how Yahweh punished Judah. People hissed or made the whistling sound that people make when they want someone to feel ashamed. Hezekiah says the Levites know these things are true because they have seen it with their own eyes. This is special language that means the men have seen these things happen.

In the original language, Hezekiah uses a special word to draw extra attention to what Hezekiah says next. The men's fathers, or ancestors, have "fallen by the sword." This phrase refers to the way an enemy uses a sword, a sharp weapon, to badly wound a person in battle so that the person falls down on the ground and dies. Also, the men's sons, daughters, and wives are in captivity. This means that Judah's enemies took the men's wives and children away to other countries as prisoners. Hezekiah reminds the men that this happened because Yahweh was very angry with them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the way a person dies in a violent way in battle? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah says it is in Hezekiah's "heart" to make a covenant with Yahweh, Israel's God. In the Bible, the heart is special language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. A covenant is a special promise that people make to each other. So Hezekiah has decided that the people of Judah must promise to be faithful to Yahweh. The people must do this so that Yahweh will no longer be angry with the people.

In the fourth scene, Hezekiah calls the men "my sons." This is special language that shows the close relationship the Levites have with the king. Hezekiah says not to be lazy or neglect the work Yahweh gave the men. Yahweh

chose these men to stand in Yahweh's presence, to minister to Yahweh, and to be Yahweh's ministers. Each of these phrases means almost the same thing: to serve Yahweh and lead other people in worship. Hezekiah says these three different ways to emphasize it more strongly. Hezekiah also says Yahweh chose these men to burn incense to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you emphasize something in a stronger way by the way you say it? If you do not have similar phrases like this in your language, how will you emphasize what Hezekiah says? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, the storyteller says the Levites arise. This is special language that means the men got ready to do what Hezekiah said to do. The storyteller gives a list of each Levite clan and its leaders. From the Kohathite clan, the leaders are Mahath, Amasai's son, and Joel, Azariah's son. From the Merarite clan, the leaders are Kish, Abdi's son, and Azariah, Jehallel's son. From the Gershonite clan, the leaders are Joah, Zimmah's son, and Eden, Joah's son. From Elizaphan's descendants, the leaders are Shimri and Jeiel. From Asaph's descendants, the leaders are Zechariah and Mattaniah. From Heman's descendants, the leaders are Jehiel and Shimei. And from Jeduthan's descendants, the leaders are Shemaiah and Uzziel.

Each of these leaders gathers the men of their clan together. The men make themselves ritually clean and holy to serve Yahweh. Then the men go in to clean Yahweh's temple. The men do what King Hezekiah commands, according to Yahweh's law. This could refer to how Yahweh instructed Hezekiah to cleanse the temple, but it more likely refers to Yahweh's instructions in the law. So the priests go into Yahweh's temple and remove the things that make the temple impure. The priests bring these things out to the temple courtyard. Then the Levites carry these things away to the Kidron Valley. You will remember that the Kidron Valley was a valley to the east of Jerusalem.

Stop here as a group and again look at a map that shows Jerusalem and the Kidron Valley, if needed. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller ends by telling how long it took the priests and other Levites to finish this work. The men began to consecrate, or make the temple holy, on the first day of the first month. On the eighth day of the month, the men finished making the courtyard holy and reached the porch of Yahweh's temple. Then, for eight more days, the men continued to make holy the inside of Yahweh's temple. Finally, the men finished on the 16th day of the first month.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1-17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hezekiah, Judah's king
- Abijah, who is Zechariah's daughter and Hezekiah's mother
- Yahweh
- King David, Hezekiah's ancestor
- The Levites
- The priests, who are also Levites
- The people of Judah
- The people's ancestors
- And the leaders of the Levite clans

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Hezekiah becomes Judah’s king when Hezekiah is 25 years old. Hezekiah rules Judah from the city of Jerusalem for 29 years. Hezekiah’s mother’s name is Abijah. Abijah is the daughter of a man whose name is Zechariah. Hezekiah does things that please Yahweh, just like Hezekiah’s ancestor, King David, did.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that Hezekiah wants to serve me and do what is right; or
- I will allow Hezekiah to be Judah’s king for a long time.

Ask the person playing Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I want to be a better king than my father, Ahaz, was; or
- I want to serve Yahweh. I will try to be like my ancestor, King David.

Continue the drama.

During King Hezekiah’s first month as king, Hezekiah opens the doors of Yahweh’s temple and has people fix the doors.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the workers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are happy that we can help make these doors beautiful again.

Ask the people playing the people of Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- Some of us remember when King Ahaz closed Yahweh’s temple. We are glad to see the temple open again; or
- Some of us are too young to remember when people worshipped at this temple. We do not know Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

Hezekiah gathers the priests and Levites on the east side of the temple. Then Hezekiah speaks to all of the men: “You people from Levi’s tribe, listen to me! Make yourselves holy for Yahweh, and also make Yahweh’s temple holy. Yahweh was your ancestors’ God. Get rid of the dirty things from the inner room of the temple. Our ancestors did not keep their promises to Yahweh. Our ancestors did evil things that Yahweh, our God, did not like. Our ancestors abandoned Yahweh. Our ancestors turned their backs on the place where Yahweh lives. Our ancestors ignored Yahweh altogether. Our ancestors also closed the doors at the entrance of the temple and made the fire stop burning in the lamps. Our ancestors no longer burned incense for Yahweh in the inner room or made burnt offerings to Israel’s God. Because of this, Yahweh has become angry with Judah and the city of Jerusalem. Yahweh has made people from other nations feel shocked and horrified when they see Yahweh’s people, so that those people greatly disrespect Yahweh’s people. You have seen this yourselves. This is why people killed our ancestors in battle, and why people have taken our sons, our daughters, and our wives as prisoners. So today, I want to renew the strong agreement we made with Yahweh, the God of Israel’s people, so that Yahweh will stop being angry with us.”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel ashamed that my father, Ahaz, led the people of Judah to worship idols; or
- I do not want Yahweh to be angry with us. I hope Yahweh will forgive us.

Ask the people playing the Levites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- I think King Hezekiah is right. Yahweh has been punishing us; or
- I agree with King Ahaz. We must obey and serve Yahweh; or
- King Hezekiah acts very differently than King Ahaz did. Hezekiah is a wise king.

Continue the drama.

“Do not be lazy any longer, my sons. Yahweh chose you to stand in Yahweh’s presence and to serve Yahweh. Yahweh chose you to be Yahweh’s workers and to burn Yahweh’s offerings.”

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Levites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We can tell that Hezekiah cares about us very much. Hezekiah speaks to us like we are Hezekiah’s family or close friends; or
- We feel honored that Yahweh chose us to do this special work to serve Yahweh; or
- It has been a long time since our people worked in the temple. We hope the work is not too difficult.

Continue the drama.

After King Hezekiah finishes speaking, the Levites start to work. From Kohath’s clan, the leaders are Mahath, Amasai’s son, and Joel, Azariah’s son. From Merari’s clan, the leaders are Kish, Abdi’s son, and Azariah, Jehallel’s son. From Gershon’s clan, the leaders are Joah, Zimmah’s son, and Eden, Joah’s son. From Elizaphan’s descendants, the leaders are Shimri and Jeiel. From Asaph’s descendants, the leaders are Zechariah and Mattaniah. From Heman’s descendants, the leaders are Jehiel and Shimei. And from Jeduthun’s descendants, the leaders are Shemaiah and Uzziel.

After the leaders brought all the other Levites together, the Levites all purified themselves to serve Yahweh. Then the Levites purified Yahweh’s temple, just as the king told them to do, according to Yahweh’s instructions. The priests entered Yahweh’s temple to make the temple holy. The priests brought everything from inside that was unclean out to the courtyard. Then the Levites took those things away to the Kidron Valley.

The priests and Levites began to purify Yahweh’s temple on the first day of the first month. By the eighth day of the month, the priests and Levites finished with the courtyard and reached the entrance to Yahweh’s temple. Then for eight more days, the priests and Levites purified Yahweh’s temple itself to make it holy, and they finished on the first month’s 16th day.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- I am surprised that there are so many things in the temple that we need to remove; or
- I did not expect it to take us this many days to clean the temple!

Ask the people playing the Levites who are not priests, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are disappointed that we are not allowed to go into the temple like the priests; or
- The priests had a lot of work to do in the temple! or
- We are glad we do not have to stay in the Kidron Valley very long. The Kidron Valley is not a very nice place. We would rather be at Yahweh’s temple, where we feel close to Yahweh.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1-17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah began to **reign** when Hezekiah was 25 years old. You will remember that to reign means to rule or act with power as king. Use the same word or phrase for reign as you used in previous passages.

Hezekiah opens the doors of Yahweh's house. Yahweh's house is another way to say Yahweh's **temple**. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh's house or temple as you used in previous passages. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Hezekiah gathered the **priests** and the **Levites**. Use the same words or phrases for priests and Levites as you used in previous passages. For more information on priest and Levite, refer to the Master Glossary.

The priests and Levites must **consecrate** themselves and the temple. To consecrate a person or thing means to set that person or thing apart for special service to God or to make it holy. In the Old Testament, when a priest or Levite consecrated himself, it meant they did not have sexual relations with their wife for a certain amount of time, and then they had to take a special bath and put on fresh clothes. To consecrate the temple and all the objects in the temple, the priests sprinkled the blood of animals they had sacrificed in the temple and over the objects in the temple. Use the same word or phrase for consecrate as you used in previous passages. For more information, refer to consecrate in the Master Glossary.

Hezekiah refers to **Yahweh** as the **God** of the people's **fathers**. God is the general name for the most powerful spiritual being who created everything, and Yahweh is God's personal name. "Fathers" means ancestors. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh, God, and fathers as you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up Yahweh and God in the Master Glossary.

The people's ancestors did **evil**. Use the same word or phrase for evil as you used in previous passages. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Levites must take the dirty things out of the **Holy Place**. This refers to the middle room of the temple. Use the same word or phrase for Holy Place as you used in previous passages, where Holy Place referred to this room. For more information on Holy Place, refer to the Master Glossary.

The people's ancestors turned their faces away from Yahweh's **dwelling place**, or the place where Yahweh lives. In this passage, this refers to the temple, but in the original language, the same phrase can refer to the tabernacle, which was Yahweh's dwelling place or house before the temple. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for dwelling place or house as you used in previous passages.

The people's ancestors put out the **lamps**. You will remember that Yahweh instructed Moses how to make the lampstand in Exodus 25:31-40, and that this lampstand held seven oil lamps. These lamps symbolized the way that Yahweh led the people of Israel, and the priests were supposed to make sure these lamps always kept burning. Use the same word or phrase for lamps as you used in previous passages. For more information about the kind of lamps people used in Judah at this time, look up **oil lamp** in the Master Glossary.

Stop here as a group and look at a drawing of what the lampstand in the temple might have looked like. Pause this audio here.

The priests had also stopped **burning incense** and offering **burnt offerings** in the **sanctuary**. People make incense from things like spices and wood that smell very good when people burn the incense in a fire. The priests would burn incense as an offering to Yahweh. A burnt offering is a form of sacrifice where a person kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar, which is a special place meant for bringing gifts to Yahweh. Here, the sanctuary refers to the whole temple complex. Use the same words or phrases for burning incense, burnt offerings, and sanctuary as you used in previous passages. For more information on burnt offerings and sanctuary, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh's **wrath** came on Judah and Jerusalem. Wrath is the attitude Yahweh has when Yahweh sees sin and evil. Wrath is stronger than anger. Look up wrath in the Master Glossary for more information. Use the same word or phrase for wrath as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh made people from other nations feel horrified when those people saw how Yahweh punished Judah. In the original language, this literally means the people trembled or felt very afraid when they saw how Yahweh punished the people of Judah.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **horrified**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The people of other nations also felt “astonished,” or surprised. This is a similar idea to horrified. This word means to feel shocked by a bad thing that happens.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe how the people felt **astonished**. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah says the people’s ancestors were killed by the **sword**. A sword is a long, sharp weapon that people make from metal. People use a sword to fight and injure others in battle. A sword has a handle to hold and a blade to cut or stab. A sword is usually longer than a knife. Use the same word or phrase for sword as you used in previous passages.

It is in Hezekiah’s **heart** to make a **covenant** with Yahweh. “Heart” is special language for the place where a person’s thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. When people make a covenant, those people make a solemn promise to each other that they cannot break. Use the same words or phrases for heart and covenant as you used in previous passages. For more information on heart and covenant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh has chosen the Levites to minister to Yahweh and to make offerings to Yahweh. To minister means to do the work of a servant, or to do work for someone who is more important.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **minister**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

An **offering** is a gift or sacrifice to Yahweh. People can make offerings for many reasons, including to give thanks, to be purified, or to ask forgiveness for sin. Use the same word or phrase for offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

The priests and Levites cleanse, or purify, the temple. To cleanse means to make something ritually clean or holy.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **cleanse**, or **purify**. Look up purify in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 29:18–30

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The events in this story happened some time after Hezekiah, king of Judah, had told the priests and the Levites to consecrate themselves and the temple of Yahweh, and after the priests and the Levites had finished consecrating themselves and the temple. The events in this story happened in Jerusalem.

This story is about how King Hezekiah, the priests, and the Levites started doing the worship service at the temple again. King Hezekiah did this because Hezekiah wanted to make a covenant with Yahweh so that Yahweh would stop being angry at Hezekiah and at the Israelites, because the ancestors of the Israelites had done evil things.

The priests and the Levites go to King Hezekiah and report that they have purified the entire temple of Yahweh, the altar of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table for setting out the bread of the presence, with all the utensils that the priests used in the temple.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of the altar with all the utensils and the table for the bread of the presence with all the utensils. Pause this audio here.

When you consecrate or sanctify someone, you set the person apart for special service to Yahweh. People can also consecrate or sanctify an object to do a special task for Yahweh. At that time, the priests and Levites consecrated an object by sprinkling the blood of animals they had sacrificed in the temple over that object. These objects were now holy—they belonged to Yahweh. People could not use these objects for ordinary use. If people did, that would be a terrible insult to Yahweh. These utensils are the things the priests used during the worship time at the temple of Yahweh, including the special tools and dishes.

The priests and the Levites say that they have prepared and consecrated all the utensils that King Ahaz removed when Ahaz was unfaithful to Yahweh. All the articles are now again in front of Yahweh's altar. You will remember in earlier stories that when King Ahaz was ruling as the king, King Ahaz took these utensils from the temple to use the utensils to worship idols. The priests and the Levites have brought back all these utensils into the temple.

Early the next morning, King Hezekiah gathers the officials or leaders of the city together and goes up to Yahweh's temple. King Hezekiah and the officials bring seven bulls, seven rams, seven male lambs, and seven male goats as a sin offering for the royal family of Judah, for Yahweh's temple, and for the rest of the kingdom. We know from the context of the passage that the male goats were for the sin offering. The priests sacrifice the bulls, rams, and male lambs as a burnt offering. A ram is an adult male sheep, usually over one year old. A lamb refers specifically to a young sheep that is less than one year old.

Stop here and, as a group, look at pictures of a bull, sheep, ram, lamb, and goat. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah and the officials brought these animals to sacrifice as offerings to remove the sin people had done in the royal family, in Yahweh's temple, and in the land of Judah.

King Hezekiah commands the priests, the descendants of Aaron, to offer the animals on the altar of Yahweh. So the people slaughter, or kill, the bulls, and the priests take the blood, and splash the blood against the altar. Next, the priests slaughter the rams and splash the rams' blood against the altar. Then the priests slaughter the lambs and splash the lambs' blood against the altar.

The priests then bring the goats for the sin or purification offering before the king and the people, and the king and the people lay their hands on the goats. Laying hands on the goats symbolizes that the people have transferred their sins onto the animals. The animals die in place of the people who have sinned so that the people do not have to receive God's punishment for the people's sin.

The priests then kill the goats and present the blood of the goats as a sin offering on the altar to make atonement for all Israel. When someone makes atonement, they restore the relationship between people or groups of people. The king had commanded the priests to make the burnt offering and the sin or purification offering for all the people of Israel. The people had broken their relationship with Yahweh because of the sin the people committed. By making atonement, the people restore their relationship with Yahweh, and Yahweh cleanses the people of their sins.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people do to restore the broken relationship between a person and God, a person and gods, or a person and spirits? Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple of Yahweh with cymbals, harps, and lyres. Hezekiah followed the same placement that David used for the temple musicians. Yahweh had commanded David to do so through the prophet Gad, who was King David's seer, and through Nathan the prophet. [You will remember that Gad was a prophet who served in David's royal court.]{mark} You may also remember that people frequently used cymbals, harps, and lyres as musical instruments in worship.

A cymbal was a musical instrument that consisted of two metal discs that a person struck together in order to make a shrill, clashing sound. People made cymbals with copper or bronze at that time.

Stop here and look at a picture of a cymbal. Pause this audio here.

The harp and lyre are stringed instruments. The harp has 10 to 13 strings of unequal length. A harp does not have a connecting yoke like a lyre. A person plays a harp by plucking its strings to make music. A lyre has a rectangular sound box with two arms and a yoke that connects the two arms. Lyres had from four to eight strings of about the same length. A lyre is usually smaller than a harp, and a person plays a lyre to make music by plucking the strings.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a harp and a lyre. Pause this audio here.

So the Levites stand ready with the same kinds of instruments that King David had used, and the priests stand with their trumpets. It is unlikely that King David's own instruments were still in working condition after 300 years. A trumpet is a long, straight instrument that musicians blow air into. The trumpet had a limited range of notes. People made trumpets from hammered metal, either silver or bronze. Priests played these trumpets to sound an alarm in times of war or to produce music in times of celebration.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a trumpet. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah gives the priests the order to sacrifice the burnt offering on the altar. The priests sacrifice the seven bulls, seven rams, and seven male lambs on the altar, as prescribed by the Law of Moses. As the priests begin the burnt offering, the musicians also begin singing to Yahweh. The priests join the singing by blowing the trumpets, and the Levites join the singing by playing the musical instruments of David, king of Israel.

All the people there bow in worship while the musicians play and the priests blow the trumpets. The people continue doing all these things until the priests have finished burning the offerings. When the sacrifice of burnt offerings is finished, King Hezekiah and everyone present with Hezekiah kneel down and worship Yahweh.

King Hezekiah and his officials order the Levites to sing praise songs to Yahweh with the words of David and the seer or prophet Asaph. So the Levites sing praise songs joyfully and bow down and worship Yahweh.

King David and the prophet Asaph were the authors of many of the Psalms, so it is probable that “the words of David and Asaph” refers to the songs that David and Asaph composed. Asaph was the Levite whom David appointed to oversee the musical parts of the worship in the temple.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The priests and the Levites go to King Hezekiah and tell King Hezekiah that they have purified the entire temple.

In the second scene: Early the next morning, King Hezekiah gathers officials of the city and goes to Yahweh’s temple with animals for a sin offering.

In the third scene: King Hezekiah commands the priests to offer the animals on the altar. The priests kill the bulls, rams, and lambs, and throw the blood on the altar. Then the priests kill the male goats and offer the male goats as sin offerings to make atonement for all the people of Israel.

In the fourth scene: King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple with different musical instruments. King Hezekiah commands the priests to sacrifice the burnt offerings on the altar. While the priests sacrifice the burnt offerings, the musicians begin to sing and play the musical instruments. The people bow in worship to Yahweh.

In the fifth scene: When the offerings finish burning, King Hezekiah and everyone present with Hezekiah kneel down and worship Yahweh. Then, King Hezekiah and his officials order the Levites to sing praise songs to Yahweh.

The characters in this passage are:

- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- The city officials
- The people who gathered at the temple of Yahweh
- And the musicians

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage’s setting:

In scene one, the priests and the Levites go to King Hezekiah and report that they have purified the entire temple of Yahweh, the altar of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table for setting out the bread of the presence, with all the equipment associated with it. The priests and Levites had made holy all the things that King Ahaz removed from the temple when King Ahaz was unfaithful to Yahweh, or betrayed Yahweh. All the actions in scene one probably happened at King Hezekiah’s palace.

In scene two, King Hezekiah gathers the city officials together and goes up to Yahweh’s temple early the next morning. King Hezekiah and the officials bring seven bulls, seven rams, seven male lambs, and seven male goats as a sin or purification offering for the kingdom, for the sanctuary or temple, and for Judah. In this context, the kingdom refers to the royal family, while Judah refers to the rest of the people in the kingdom of Judah. When the storyteller says “the sanctuary,” the storyteller is referring to the temple and the people who serve in the temple.

Stop and discuss: How will you translate each of these groups of people so that people in your culture understand who the storyteller is referring to? Pause this audio here.

The number seven is a special number in many cultures of this area, including the people of Judah. The number seven is also an important number in the Bible as a symbol of completeness or fullness. By offering seven of each animal, King Hezekiah is emphasizing the importance of the sacrifice.

In scene three, King Hezekiah commands the priests, who are the descendants of Aaron, to offer the animals on the altar of Yahweh. In the original language, it is not clear who killed the bulls. It may be the priests, or it may be King Hezekiah and his officials. It may also be King Hezekiah, his officials, and the priests. However, according to the instructions Yahweh gave to Moses, the people making the burnt offering were usually the ones who actually slaughtered the animals. So, it is most likely that King Hezekiah and his officials killed the bulls. The priests take the blood from the slaughtered bulls and splash the blood against the altar. Next, the priests slaughter the rams and splash the rams' blood against the altar. Then, the priests slaughter the lambs and splash the lambs' blood against the altar.

The priests then bring the goats for the sin or purification offering before King Hezekiah and the people there, and King Hezekiah and the people lay their hands on the goats. Then, the priests kill the goats and present the blood of the goats as a sin or purification offering on the altar to make atonement for all Israel, because King Hezekiah has commanded the priests to make the burnt offering and the sin or purification offering for all the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group: If you have already translated Leviticus into your language, listen to your translation of Leviticus 4. Discuss how you will translate this section about the sin or purification offering. Pause this audio here.

After the priests kill the animals, the storyteller repeats King Hezekiah's command to emphasize that the king commanded the priests to make burnt offerings and sin or purification offerings for all of Israel.

In scene four, King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple of Yahweh with cymbals, harps, and lyres, in the way David and Gad, King David's seer, and Nathan the prophet had ordered many years before. A seer is another word for "prophet." People called Gad King David's seer, because Gad served in David's royal court as an advisor. Here, the storyteller explains that Yahweh, through Yahweh's prophets, commanded the Israelites to have Levites with musical instruments in Yahweh's temple. Yahweh commanded the Israelites to do so about 300 years ago, during the time of King David.

Then, the Levites stand ready with the instruments like those King David had used, and the priests stand with their trumpets. Hezekiah gives the priests the order to sacrifice the burnt offering on the altar. As the priests begin offering, the musicians also begin singing to Yahweh. The priests join the singing by blowing the trumpets, and the Levites join the singing by playing the musical instruments like those King David used.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story in which two events happened at the same time. In your language, how do people usually talk about two events that occur at the same time? Discuss how you will tell that the musical worship happened at the same time as the sacrifices. Pause this audio here.

All the people there bow in worship, while the musicians play and the priests blow the trumpets. The people continue doing all these things until the priests have finished burning the offerings.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do people use music in worship? When does music accompany worship rituals and activities? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, when the offerings finish burning, King Hezekiah and everyone present with Hezekiah kneel down and worship Yahweh. King Hezekiah and his officials order the Levites to sing praise songs to Yahweh with the words of David and the seer Asaph. So the Levites sing praise songs joyfully and bow down and worship Yahweh.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- The city officials
- The people who gathered at the temple of Yahweh
- And the musicians

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

All the actions in scene one probably happened at King Hezekiah’s palace.

The priests and the Levites go to King Hezekiah and report that they have purified the entire temple of Yahweh, the altar of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table for setting out the bread of the presence, with all the equipment associated with it.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priest, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am very tired but excited to let King Hezekiah know what we have accomplished; or
- I am looking forward to leading the worship service at the temple of Yahweh soon; or
- I will need to study all the laws for offering sacrifices so that I do not miss any steps.

Continue the drama.

King Hezekiah gathers the city officials together and goes up to Yahweh’s temple early the next morning. King Hezekiah and the officials bring seven bulls, seven rams, seven male lambs, and seven male goats as a sin offering for the royal family of Judah, for Yahweh’s temple, and for the rest of the kingdom.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the city officials, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am very happy to get to serve a leader like King Hezekiah; or
- I have not worshipped Yahweh in many years. I am very excited now; or
- I hope Yahweh will accept our offerings and forgive our sins.

Continue the drama.

King Hezekiah commands the priests, the descendants of Aaron, to offer the animals on the altar of Yahweh. So the people slaughter the bulls, and the priests take the blood and splash the blood against the altar. Next, the priests slaughter the rams and splash the rams’ blood against the altar. Then the priests slaughter the lambs and splash the lambs’ blood against the altar.

The priests then bring the goats for the sin offering before the king and the people there, and the king and the people lay their hands on the goats. Then the priests kill the goats and present the blood of the goats as a sin offering on the altar to make atonement for all Israel because King Hezekiah commanded the priests to make the burnt offering and the sin offering for all the people of Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the priests, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- King Hezekiah and the people are serious about making atonement for their sins. They brought seven of each kind of animal; or
- I am grateful that King Hezekiah is helping us return to the proper worship of Yahweh.

Ask the person playing one of the people gathered at the temple, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that we now have a restored relationship with Yahweh; or
- I am so excited that the priests have made these offerings for us. Now Yahweh has forgiven our sins. It has been a long time!

Continue the drama.

King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple of Yahweh with cymbals, harps, and lyres in the way David and Gad, who was king David’s seer and Nathan the prophet, prescribed. Yahweh commanded the Israelites to do so through Yahweh’s prophets. So the Levites stand ready with musical instruments like those David used, and the priests stand with their trumpets.

Hezekiah commands the priests to sacrifice the burnt offering on the altar. As the priests begin offering, the musicians also begin singing to Yahweh. The priests join the singing by blowing the trumpets and the Levites join the singing by playing the musical instruments of David, king of Israel.

All the people there bow in worship, while the musicians play and the priests blow the trumpets. The people continue doing all these things until the priests have finished burning the offerings. When the offerings finish burning, King Hezekiah and everyone present with the king kneel down and worship Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing a Levite who plays a musical instrument, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel peace and joy when I play music to worship Yahweh; or
- I am very happy to use my skill as a musician during the worship service; or
- Yahweh is worthy of our worship and praise. I cannot help but play my instrument for Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

King Hezekiah and his officials order the Levites to sing praise songs to Yahweh with the words of David and the seer or the prophet Asaph. So the Levites sing praise songs joyfully and bow down and worship Yahweh.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The **priests** and the **Levites** go to **King** Hezekiah and report that they have **purified** the entire **temple** of **Yahweh**, the **altar** of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table for setting out the **bread of the presence**, with all the utensils associated with it. Use the same words for priests, Levites, King, purify, temple, Yahweh, altar, and bread of the presence as you used in the previous passages. For more information on priests, Levites, king, purify, temple, Yahweh, altar, and “bread of the presence,” refer to the Master Glossary.

A **burnt offering** is a form of sacrifice that people bring to Yahweh. When a person brings Yahweh a burnt offering, that person kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar. When a person brings Yahweh a burnt offering, that person is saying to Yahweh, “Just as I am completely burning this animal, I am completely devoted to you.” Use the same word or phrase for burnt offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on burnt offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

The priests said that they **consecrated** all of the utensils that King Ahaz had taken out of the temple. When you consecrate someone, you set the person apart for special service to Yahweh. You could also consecrate an object to do a special task for Yahweh. Use the same word or phrase for consecrate as you used in previous passages. For more information on consecrate, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Hezekiah and the officials bring seven bulls, seven rams, seven lambs, and seven male goats as a sin or purification offering for the “kingdom” or royal family of Judah, for Yahweh’s temple, and for the rest of the kingdom of Judah. People also called the sin offering a purification offering or a purification sacrifice because the purpose of this offering was to purify someone who had become unclean or unfit to serve Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sin or purification offering**. Look up “sin or purification offering” in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

If you use the term for “**kingdom**” instead of royal family, refer to kingdom in the Master Glossary for more information and translate kingdom in the same way you have previously. Use the same word for important **officials** and **Judah** as you have used previously, and refer to Judah in the Master Glossary for more information.

Use the same word or phrase for **slaughter**, or kill an animal, as you have used in previous passages.

Later, the priests bring the goats to the **assembly**, or gathering of people, and they kill the goats and present the blood of the goats as a sin offering on the altar to make atonement for all Israel. The people had broken their relationship with Yahweh because of the sin the people committed. By making atonement, the people restore their relationship with Yahweh, and Yahweh cleanses the people of their sins. Use the same word or phrase for assembly, or “special gathering of people,” as you have used previously.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **atonement**. Look up atonement in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple of Yahweh with **cymbals, harps, and lyres** in the way David and Gad, who was king David’s **seer** and Nathan the **prophet**, prescribed. A prophet is a person who gives messages from Yahweh to the people. A seer is another word for a prophet. People called Gad King David’s seer because Gad served as an advisor in David’s royal court. Use the same words or phrases for cymbals, harps, lyres, prophet, and seer as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet, refer to the Master Glossary.

Later, all the people at the temple of Yahweh **bow in worship** while the musicians play and the priests blow the **trumpets**. In the original language, the storyteller simply says “bow down,” meaning that the people worshiped. When a person bows down before someone else, that person lowers their head or the whole top of their body forward. Sometimes people even stretched themselves out flat on the ground in front of a person. People do this to show respect and humility. When a person worships Yahweh, that person gives honor to Yahweh. That person is saying that Yahweh deserves all of that person’s thanks, praise, and respect. Worship is not just performing rituals for Yahweh; it is about having a heart of awe and wonder towards Yahweh. Use the same words for trumpets, bow, and worship as you used in previous passages. For more information on bow and worship, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 29:31–36

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, King Hezekiah commanded the priests to offer burnt offerings and sin or purification offerings for the royal family, the temple, and the people of Judah. Through these offerings, the people made atonement for their sin. The people bowed in worship while the priests made the offerings, and the Levites praised Yahweh with instruments and singing.

Now, Hezekiah says to the people that since the people have consecrated themselves to Yahweh, the people should come and bring sacrifices and thank offerings to Yahweh's temple. So the people there bring sacrifices and thank offerings. Sacrifices are offerings of sheep, goats, or cattle that people give to worship Yahweh, confirm their relationship with Yahweh, or ask forgiveness for something people have done wrong. A sacrifice could involve the killing of an animal, and then the priest would burn some parts of the animal on the altar. Thank offerings are sacrifices that people give to thank Yahweh for answered prayer.

Some people have a willing heart and make a voluntary sacrifice of burnt offerings. The people who brought voluntary burnt offerings were considered generous because the priests burned all the meat from those offerings on the altar. You will remember that for other sacrifices and thank offerings, the person who gave the offering ate what the priests did not burn.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone who did a good thing they did not have to do, or about someone who did more than was expected. Pay attention to how the storyteller describes this kind of person. What do people in your culture think about this kind of voluntary action? Pause this audio here.

The people bring 70 bulls, 100 rams, and 200 male lambs as burnt offerings. All these animals are for burnt offerings to Yahweh. When a person brings Yahweh a burnt offering, that person kills an animal, and the priest burns this animal completely on the altar. The people bring 600 bulls and 3,000 sheep and goats as consecrated or holy sacrifices.

However, there are not enough priests who are ritually clean to skin all of the animals for burnt offerings. So the Levites help the priests finish skinning the animals until other priests have consecrated themselves. Levites have done better at keeping themselves pure for Yahweh than the priests have.

According to the instructions Yahweh gave to Moses, the people who brought the sacrifices were the ones who had to skin the animals, not the priests. There were so many offerings this day that there was not enough space in the temple courtyard for all the people to skin the animals. This is probably the reason why the Levites helped the priests finish skinning the animals.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people usually do to purify themselves to worship God, gods, or the spirits? Pause this audio here.

There is a large number of burnt offerings, together with the fat of peace or fellowship offerings and the drink offerings that go with the burnt offerings. In the peace or fellowship offerings, the priests burned some of the offering on the altar, and the priests and the persons making the offering ate the rest of the offering. The purpose of peace or fellowship offerings was to establish or maintain good relations with Yahweh. The fat of the peace or fellowship offerings refers to the fatty animal parts of these offerings. Drink offerings are gifts of wine that priests pour onto the altar along with the other offerings. Wine is fermented grape juice.

So, the people begin to worship Yahweh again in the temple. Then Hezekiah rejoices along with all of Yahweh's people because Yahweh has helped them to renew worship in the temple very quickly.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one scene.

In the scene: Hezekiah says to the people that they should bring sacrifices and thank offerings to Yahweh's temple. So the people do as Hezekiah says. The Levites help the priests skin the animals. Then, Hezekiah rejoices along with all of Yahweh's people.

The characters in this passage are:

- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- The city officials who are probably still there, although the storyteller does not mention them
- The people who gathered at Yahweh's temple
- And the musicians who are probably still there, although the storyteller does not mention them

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Hezekiah says to the people that since they have now consecrated themselves to Yahweh, the people should come and bring sacrifices and thank offerings to Yahweh's temple. So the people there bring sacrifices and thank offerings, and all who are of a willing heart also bring burnt offerings. The sacrifices and thank offerings required that the priests burn only part of the meat. The people who made the offerings ate what the priests did not burn. But the burnt offerings indicated a special generosity since the priests burned all of the meat on the altar. Offerings that people made "with a willing heart" refer to sacrifices that people made because they wanted to, not because Yahweh required the people to. In other words, the storyteller is saying that the people who brought burnt offerings were generous.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think back to your discussion about people who do more than expected. How will you translate the idea that some people gave from a willing heart? Pause this audio here.

The story action stops briefly while the storyteller shares the total number of animals the assembly, or group of people, gave as burnt offerings and sacrifices. The number of burnt offerings the people bring is 70 bulls, 100

rams, and 200 male lambs. The number of animals the people “consecrated,” or set apart as sacrifices, is 600 bulls and 3,000 sheep and goats.

You may remember that according to the instructions Yahweh gave to Moses, the people who brought the sacrifices were the ones who had to skin the animals, not the priests. There were so many offerings this day that there probably was not enough space in the temple courtyard for all the people to skin the animals. The storyteller continues and notes that there are not enough priests to skin all the animals for burnt offerings. So the Levites help the priests finish skinning the animals until other priests have consecrated themselves.

The Levites helped the priests because the Levites had done better at keeping themselves pure for Yahweh than the priests had. In the original language, the storyteller says that the Levites are more “upright in heart” than the priests. This is special language that people used to describe obedience. The Levites were more faithful and more diligent to keep themselves ritually pure than the priests were.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture describe someone who is faithful and diligent? How will you translate the idea that the Levites were more “upright in heart”? Pause this audio here

In addition to the large number of burnt offerings, there was the fat of the peace or fellowship offerings and the drink offerings that went along with the burnt offerings. The priests were very busy with the added work responsibilities of these offerings.

So, the people began to worship Yahweh again in the temple. Then Hezekiah and all the people rejoiced because God had helped them do all these things very quickly.

King Hezekiah rejoiced because Yahweh helped King Hezekiah, the priests, the Levites, and the Israelites to restart or renew worship in the temple in the first month of the first year that Hezekiah was king. That is why the storyteller said that all the things happened very quickly.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture express their joy when they are happy about something? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one scene.

The characters in this passage are:

- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- The city officials who are probably still there, although the storyteller does not mention them
- The people who gathered at Yahweh’s temple
- And the musicians who are probably still there, although the storyteller does not mention them

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Hezekiah says to the people, “You have now consecrated yourselves to Yahweh. Come and bring sacrifices and thank offerings to the temple of Yahweh.” So the people there bring sacrifices and thank offerings, and all who are of a willing heart also bring burnt offerings.

The number of burnt offerings the people bring is 70 bulls, 100 rams, and 200 male lambs. All these animals are for burnt offerings to Yahweh. The number of animals people set apart as sacrifices is 600 bulls and 3,000 sheep and goats.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the people gathered at the temple, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy to be able to worship Yahweh like this again. I am going to bring a special burnt offering to thank Yahweh; or
- This is so exciting. I have never seen so many people in the temple at one time; or
- There sure are a lot of animals. I hope we can get to my sacrifice today.

Continue the drama.

However, there are not enough priests to skin all of the animals for burnt offerings. So the Levites help the priests finish skinning the animals until other priests have consecrated themselves. This is because the Levites have done better at keeping themselves pure for Yahweh than the priests have.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the Levites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am very proud to be able to help the people sacrifice and worship Yahweh; or
- I am surprised because I have never seen this many animals in one place before; or
- I probably will not be able to smell or eat meat for about a month after this.

Continue the drama.

In addition to the large number of burnt offerings, there was the fat of the peace offerings and the drink offerings that went along with the burnt offerings.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the priests, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- There sure is a lot of work to do. I am glad the Levites are helping us skin the burnt offerings; or
- I am so happy to be doing things properly again in the temple; or
- I wish the other priests had been more faithful in keeping themselves ritually clean. We could have used those priests’ help today.

Continue the drama.

So, the people began to worship Yahweh again in the temple. Then, Hezekiah and the people rejoiced because God had helped them to do all these things very quickly.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am very happy because I get to be the leader who restarts the worship at Yahweh’s temple; or
- I am very thankful to Yahweh, who helped us to be able to worship at the temple again; or
- I am very hopeful that Yahweh will forgive our sins and our ancestors’ sins.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the worshippers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I cannot believe that we are worshipping Yahweh at the temple again; or
- I am happy and sad at the same time; or
- I am happy because I can worship Yahweh together with my fellow Israelites.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Hezekiah says to the people, “You have now **consecrated** yourselves to **Yahweh**. Come and bring **sacrifices** and **thank offerings** to the **temple**, the **house of Yahweh**.” A thank offering is a type of freewill offering, or offering that people bring because they want to. Use the same words for king, consecrate, Yahweh, sacrifice, thank offering, and temple or “house of Yahweh” that you have used in previous passages. For more information, refer to king, consecrate, Yahweh, sacrifice, freewill offering, temple, and **house of God** in the Master Glossary.

The number of **burnt offerings** that the “**assembly**,” or group of people, brings is 70 bulls, 100 rams, and 200 male lambs. Use the same words or phrases for assembly and for burnt offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on burnt offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

However, there are not enough **priests** to skin all of the animals for burnt offerings. So the **Levites** help the priests finish skinning the animals until other priests have consecrated themselves. Use the same words for priests and Levites that you have used in previous passages. Remember that these words are in the Master Glossary.

In addition to the large number of burnt offerings, there was the fat of the **peace or fellowship offerings** and the **drink offerings** that went along with the burnt offerings. A peace or fellowship offering is a sacrifice someone makes to have a better relationship with Yahweh. In the peace offerings, the priests burned some of the offering on the altar, and the priests and the persons who made the offering ate the rest of the offering. The fat of the peace offerings refers to the fatty animal parts of these fellowship offerings. Use the same word or phrase for “peace offering” that you have used in previous passages. For more information on peace offering, refer to “peace or fellowship offering” in the Master Glossary.

Drink offerings are gifts of wine that priests pour onto the altar along with the other offerings. Wine is fermented grape juice.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **drink offering**. Look up drink offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah and the people rejoice because **God** has helped them restore the service of the temple. Use the same word for God as you have used previously. Refer to God in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 30:1-12

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 30:1-12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1-12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1-12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Hezekiah, Hezekiah's officials, priests, Levites, and the people started the worship service again at Yahweh's temple. The events in this story happen some time later, but during King Hezekiah's reign. King Hezekiah and his officials invite other Israelites who live in the land of Israel, in the land of Judah, and other regions to come to Yahweh's temple to celebrate the Passover festival and to come back to Yahweh.

King Hezekiah sends a message to all the people in the land of Israel and in the land of Judah, even though King Hezekiah is king in the kingdom of Judah only. King Hezekiah also writes letters to the people in the territories of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh. In King Hezekiah's message, King Hezekiah invites all the Israelites to come to Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem and celebrate the Passover to honor Yahweh, the God of Israel.

You will remember that Passover is an important Jewish feast that begins the Festival, or Feast, of Unleavened Bread. During Passover, Jewish people celebrate the time Yahweh rescued the Israelites from Egypt during Moses' time. Yahweh commanded the Israelites through Moses to celebrate the Passover on the 14th day of the month of Nisan, the first month in the Hebrew calendar. If a person is ritually unclean at the time of Passover, that person could celebrate Passover in the second month.

During this year, the people could not celebrate the Passover in the first month because many priests were still ritually unclean and unable to serve in the temple. Also, the people of Judah had not gathered in Jerusalem for the festival. So, King Hezekiah, Hezekiah's officials, and the people gathered in Jerusalem decided to celebrate the Passover in the second month, as Yahweh allows in the Law of Moses. They decided to send a proclamation or announcement throughout all the land of Israel, from the city of Beersheba in the far south to the city of Dan in the far north.

Stop here and look at a map of Judah and Israel during Hezekiah's time. Locate the cities of Jerusalem, Beersheba, and Dan. Pause this audio here.

The people have not celebrated the Passover festival in great numbers, or according to the law that Yahweh gave to Moses. The last time the Israelites celebrated the Passover festival was probably during King Solomon's time. So, King Hezekiah sent messengers who carried letters from King Hezekiah and the princes or officials. These messengers went everywhere in the land of Judah and Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are the things a leader usually does when the leader wants to invite others to do something? How does the leader deliver messages to many people in many different places? Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah's message urges the Israelites to return to Yahweh, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and "Israel," who we also know as Jacob. If the Israelites return to Yahweh, Yahweh might return to the few Israelites who are left, those who have escaped or survived the attacks by the kings of Assyria. King Hezekiah is speaking to the Israelites, whom the kings of Assyria did not kill or take as prisoners when the kings of the Assyrian Empire conquered the northern kingdom of Israel in 721 B.C. King Hezekiah himself is also one of the people the kings of Assyria did not kill.

When Hezekiah tells the people to "return to Yahweh," Hezekiah is telling the Israelites to repent, stop chasing after other gods, and return to worship Yahweh once again.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that they should not be like their fathers and their brothers, who were unfaithful to Yahweh, the God of the Israelites' fathers. Because the Israelites' fathers and brothers were unfaithful to Yahweh, Yahweh made the Israelites an object of horror. King Hezekiah is saying that Yahweh brought such a terrible punishment on the Israelites that the people from surrounding nations were shocked when they saw how God punished the Israelites. The people of Israel had seen or had known very well about Yahweh's punishment.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites not to be "stiff-necked," as their fathers were. Hezekiah uses a common phrase to describe the Israelites' ancestors as stubborn and rebellious. Hezekiah tells the Israelites to obey Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about someone who was very stubborn and refused to do what he was supposed to do. Pay attention to the ways the storyteller describes this stubborn person. Pause this audio here.

Then, Hezekiah urges the Israelites to come to Yahweh's sanctuary, the temple which Yahweh has set apart for worship. Hezekiah tells the Israelites to serve or worship Yahweh, their God, so that Yahweh's fierce anger will turn away from the Israelites. Hezekiah tells the Israelites that if they come back to Yahweh, the Assyrian captors will show compassion to their Israelite brothers and their children and allow them to return to Israel because Yahweh is kind and merciful.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that Yahweh will not abandon the Israelites if they return to Yahweh. If the Israelites come back to Yahweh, Yahweh will welcome and not reject the Israelites.

The messengers go from town to town in the territories of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh, and as far north as the region where the tribe of Zebulun lives. Many people who live there laugh at and mock the messengers. However, some people from the tribes of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humble themselves and go to Jerusalem. You will remember that these tribes all separated from Judah and Benjamin when the kingdom of Israel divided.

Stop here and look at a map of the territory of the tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh, Zebulun, and Asher during King Hezekiah's time. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that the "hand" of Yahweh, or Yahweh's power, is on the people of Judah and gives the people one heart, unified for one purpose: to obey King Hezekiah and his officials and follow Yahweh's instructions.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1-12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The assembly of Israelites in Jerusalem has not been able to celebrate the Passover festival at the regular time. So, King Hezekiah, King Hezekiah's officials, and the people who have gathered in Jerusalem decide to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month. King Hezekiah sends messengers with a message to other Israelites who are in the land of Israel and Judah, urging the Israelites to come back to Yahweh.

In the second scene: The messengers go to all the places King Hezekiah commands the messengers to go and give King Hezekiah's message to the people who live in those places. Many people laugh at and mock the messengers.

In the third scene: Some people humble themselves and go to Jerusalem. Yahweh leads the people in the land of the tribe of Judah to be unified for one purpose.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Hezekiah
- King Hezekiah's officials
- The assembly in Jerusalem
- King Hezekiah's messengers
- People who live in the former kingdom of Israel, including people who live in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim, Manasseh, Asher, and Zebulun
- And people who live in the kingdom of Judah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The passage begins by saying that King Hezekiah writes a message to send to all of Israel and Judah, including Ephraim and Manasseh. Hezekiah tells the people that the people should come to Jerusalem and celebrate the Passover on the 14th day of the second month. The storyteller then says why King Hezekiah has decided to wait until the second month instead of celebrating Passover in the first month. The Israelites have not been able to celebrate the Passover festival in great numbers at the regular time because not enough priests have consecrated or purified themselves, and the people have not assembled in Jerusalem. So, King Hezekiah, King Hezekiah's officials, and the people who have gathered in Jerusalem decide to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month. Everyone in Jerusalem agrees that the plan to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month seems like the right thing to do.

[If, in your language, you do not give information in this way, you may decide to reorder the passage and give the reason first. You would first tell how the people were not able to celebrate the Passover in the first month because the priests had not consecrated themselves, and not many people came to Jerusalem in time to celebrate. Then give King Hezekiah's decision to wait until the second month.]{.mark}

Stop here and discuss how you will tell the order of the events in this passage so that the people in your culture will understand clearly. Pause this audio here.

So, King Hezekiah and all the people decide to send an announcement throughout the land of Israel. People will take the announcement from the city of Beersheba in the far south to the city of Dan in the far north, meaning the entire territory of the southern kingdom of Judah and the northern kingdom of Israel.

Stop here and look at the map of Judah and Israel during Hezekiah's time. Locate the cities of Jerusalem, Beersheba, and Dan, if needed. Discuss as a group: How will you translate this so that people will understand that Hezekiah was sending the message to the entire country? Pause this audio here.

In this announcement, Hezekiah calls all the Israelites to come to Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem and celebrate the Passover. You will remember that the Passover is one of the festivals that Jewish law requires the people to travel to Jerusalem to celebrate. Israelites have not celebrated the Passover festival in large numbers according to the Law of Moses. The last time all the Israelites celebrated the Passover festival was probably during King Solomon's time.

Then King Hezekiah commands messengers to take letters from the king and his officials to the people who live throughout the land of Israel and Judah. In the original language, the word for these messengers is similar to the word "to run" and shows that these messengers were to take the message quickly and possibly run to each location. You can also translate this word as "runners."

Stop and discuss: In your community, how do you send messages quickly to many places? How will you translate the idea of this kind of messenger in your translation? Pause this audio here.

In King Hezekiah's letter, Hezekiah urges the Israelites to return to Yahweh, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, so that Yahweh might return to the Israelites who are left, who have escaped from the "hand," or power, of the

kings of Assyria. “The hand of the kings of Assyria” refers to the Assyrian conquest of the northern kingdom of Israel. Here, Hezekiah is speaking to everyone who has escaped or survived the Assyrian army’s attacks.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that they should not be like their fathers and their brothers who were unfaithful to Yahweh, the God of their fathers. Hezekiah is not speaking about the Israelites’ actual fathers and brothers, but about the Israelites’ ancestors. Hezekiah says that the Israelites’ ancestors were unfaithful to Yahweh because they disobeyed and rebelled against Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you say that someone is unfaithful to God, gods, or spirits? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh made the Israelites’ fathers and brothers an object of horror, as the people of Israel have seen. Hezekiah is possibly referring to two things. First, Hezekiah is saying that Yahweh severely punished the disobedience of the Israelites’ ancestors. Secondly, Yahweh’s punishment was so severe that the people who saw it were very surprised. The people of Israel have seen how horrible their punishment is, and so have the other nations.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you say that Yahweh made the ancestors and the relatives of the Israelites an object of horror? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that they should not be “stiff-necked” or stubborn as their fathers were, but the people of Israel should submit to Yahweh. The term “stiff-necked” is special language. You will remember that in the story of the Exodus, Yahweh frequently described the Israelites as stiff-necked. The original meaning of the term “stiff-necked” probably comes from a farming expression. Farm animals wore yokes on their necks, and animals that stiffened their necks were stubbornly refusing to accept the yoke.

Stop here and remember your discussion from step two. How did you describe a very stubborn person, and how will you describe “stiff-necked” people in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Then, Hezekiah invites the people of Israel to come to Yahweh’s sanctuary or temple, which Yahweh has consecrated, or made holy, forever. Hezekiah tells the people of Israel to serve and worship Yahweh, their God, so that Yahweh’s fierce anger will turn away from the people. Hezekiah says that if the Israelites come back to Yahweh, the Israelites’ captors, the Assyrians, will show compassion to their brothers and their children, and allow their brothers and children to return to the land of the Israelites.

Yahweh, the Israelites’ God, is gracious and compassionate. Yahweh will not turn Yahweh’s face from the Israelites if the Israelites return to Yahweh. Here, Hezekiah is using special language. In the Old Testament, people often used the image of Yahweh turning his face toward or away from a person to mean that Yahweh was either accepting or rejecting someone. Hezekiah said that if the Israelites return to Yahweh, Yahweh will accept the Israelites rather than reject them.

Stop here and discuss: How will you translate the idea that Yahweh will accept and not reject the people if they return to Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, the messengers go from town to town in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim and in the territory of the tribe of Manasseh, as far as the region where the tribe of Zebulun lives. But people who live in those places laugh at and mock the messengers.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes all the places the messengers went. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the storyteller says that even though some people mock the messengers, some people from the tribes of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humble themselves and go to Jerusalem. The storyteller begins the next idea by showing that just as Yahweh was at work among the people of the tribes of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun in the north, so was Yahweh at work among the people of Judah in the south. The storyteller says that the hand of Yahweh is also on the people in the land of Judah. The “hand of Yahweh is on the people” is special language, meaning that Yahweh blesses or guides the people. Yahweh blesses the people with one heart, which shows that the people were unified in their purpose. The people were unified in their obedience to what King Hezekiah and his officials had ordered and followed the word, or message, of Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how will you describe the idea that Yahweh blesses or guides the people to be unified in purpose? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1-12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Hezekiah
- King Hezekiah's officials
- The assembly in Jerusalem
- King Hezekiah's messengers
- People who live in the former kingdom of Israel, including people who live in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim, Manasseh, Asher, and Zebulun
- And people who live in the kingdom of Judah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The Israelites have not been able to celebrate the Passover festival in great numbers at the regular time, according to the Law of Moses, because not enough priests have consecrated themselves, and the people have not assembled in Jerusalem. So, Hezekiah and his officials and the whole assembly in Jerusalem decide to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month. The plan seems right to both King Hezekiah and the whole assembly.

So, King Hezekiah and all the people decide to send an announcement throughout the land of Israel. People will take the announcement to all the cities, from Beersheba in the far south to Dan in the far north. King Hezekiah, his officials, and the assembly invite all the Israelites to come to Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem and celebrate the Passover festival to Yahweh, the God of Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am looking forward to celebrate the Passover festival together with other Israelites for the first time during my rule to honor Yahweh; or
- I hope Yahweh will no longer be angry with us if many of us change our lifestyles and come to Jerusalem to celebrate the Passover festival to honor Yahweh at Yahweh's temple; or
- I hope spiritual revival will happen in every place where Israelites live.

Continue the drama.

Then, King Hezekiah and his officials write letters to all the people in the land of Israel and people in the land of Judah, including the people in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim and in the territory of the tribe of Manasseh.

King Hezekiah commands messengers to take these letters to the people who live throughout the land of Israel and Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah's messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very excited to give this invitation to other Israelites; or
- I am very happy because I will soon be able to celebrate the Passover festival with other Israelites; or
- I am a bit afraid because I do not know how other Israelites who are not under King Hezekiah's rule will respond to the invitation.

Continue the drama.

In King Hezekiah's message, Hezekiah says: "People of Israel, return to Yahweh, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, so that Yahweh might return to the Israelites who are left, those of us who have escaped from the hand of Assyria's kings. Do not be like your ancestors and relatives who were unfaithful to Yahweh, the God of their fathers. Yahweh made your fathers and brothers an object of horror, as you yourselves have seen. Do not be stubborn like your ancestors were, but submit yourselves to Yahweh. Come to Yahweh's temple, the special place Yahweh has forever made holy and set apart. Worship and serve Yahweh your God so that Yahweh's fierce anger will turn away from you.

"If you return to Yahweh, then the Assyrian captors will show compassion on your brothers and children. The captors will allow your brothers and children to return to this land. Yahweh your God is gracious and merciful. Yahweh will not continue to turn his face from you and reject you if you return to Yahweh."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the people from the territory of the tribe of Ephraim, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I wonder what secret plan King Hezekiah has because King Hezekiah is not even my king; or
- I have my own idols to worship at home. Why should I spend money to go to Jerusalem to worship Yahweh? or
- I am very happy because I will soon be able to celebrate the Passover festival at Yahweh's temple for the first time in many years.

Continue the drama.

The messengers go from town to town in the territories of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh, and as far as the region where the tribe of Zebulun lives. But most of the people who live in those places laugh at and mock the messengers. However, some people from the tribes of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humble themselves and go to Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah's messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very sad because many of my fellow Israelites do not want to obey Yahweh; or
- I am very hurt because I was expecting to receive a warm welcome as I am urging people to obey Yahweh; or
- Even though many people reject the invitation I have brought with me, I am happy that there are some Israelites who want to obey Yahweh.

Ask the person playing one of the people from the tribe of Asher, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very sad because many of my fellow Israelites do not want to obey Yahweh; or
- King Hezekiah reminds me to obey Yahweh and not be like my ancestors; or
- Even though many people reject King Hezekiah's invitation, I am happy about this message and look forward to celebrating the Passover again.

Continue the drama.

The storyteller says that Yahweh also blesses and guides the people of Judah. Yahweh gives the people one heart to obey what King Hezekiah and his officials have ordered, following the word of Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing people who live in the kingdom of Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am thankful to Yahweh because I will soon be able to celebrate the Passover festival to honor Yahweh; or
- I am sad because many of my fellow Israelites do not want to celebrate the Passover festival as the Law of Moses requires; or
- I do not care what other Israelites do, but as for me, I will teach my family to worship and obey Yahweh by trying to be a good example.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1-12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Hezekiah sends a message to all the people in the land of **Israel** and in the land of **Judah**. King Hezekiah also writes letters to the people in the territories of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh. In King Hezekiah’s message, Hezekiah invites the Israelites to come to the **temple** of **Yahweh** in **Jerusalem** and celebrate the Passover to honor Yahweh, the **God** of Israel. Use the same words or phrases for king, Israel, Judah, temple, Jerusalem, God, and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, Israel, temple, Jerusalem, God, and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Passover is an important Jewish feast that begins the Festival, or Feast, of Unleavened Bread. During Passover, Jewish people celebrate the time Yahweh rescued the Israelites from Egypt during Moses’ time. Yahweh commanded the Israelites through Moses to celebrate the Passover on the 14th day of the month of Nisan, the first month in the Hebrew calendar. If a person is ritually unclean at the time of Passover, that person could celebrate Passover in the second month.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Passover**. Look up Passover in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah and his high **officials**, or princes, and the whole **assembly** in Jerusalem decide to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month. The people have not been able to celebrate the Passover festival at the regular time because not enough **priests** have **consecrated** themselves, and the people have not assembled in Jerusalem. Priests were people who worked in Yahweh’s temple in Jerusalem. When you consecrate someone, you set the person apart for special service to Yahweh. Use the same words or phrases for official, assembly, priest, and consecrate as you used in previous passages. For more information on priest and consecrate, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Hezekiah commands messengers or runners to take letters from Hezekiah and his officials to all the people living in Israel and Judah. In the original language, the word the storyteller used for these messengers is similar to the word “to run,” which shows that these messengers were to take the message quickly and that they possibly ran to each location. You can also translate this word as “runners.”

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **messengers**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In King Hezekiah’s letter, Hezekiah tells the Israelites not to be like their **fathers** and **brothers** who were faithless and stiff-necked. When Hezekiah said “fathers and brothers,” Hezekiah was referring to the Israelites’ ancestors. Use the same words for fathers and brothers that you have used in previous passages for ancestors.

The Israelites’ ancestors were “stiff-necked” or stubborn, just like a farm animal that refused to be placed in a yoke.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **stiff-necked**. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites to submit to or obey Yahweh, come to Yahweh's **sanctuary**, which Yahweh has made holy forever, and serve Yahweh, their God. A sanctuary is a holy place—a place that is set apart for the worship of Yahweh. In this context, the word sanctuary refers to the temple of Yahweh, especially the central part of the temple. Use the same word for sanctuary that you have used in previous passages. For more information on sanctuary, refer to the Master Glossary.

Hezekiah says that if the Israelites come back to Yahweh, their captors, the Assyrians, will show compassion to the Israelites' brothers and their children, and allow their brothers and children to return to the Israelites' land. When someone has compassion for someone, that person has a deep affection or love for someone.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **compassion**. Look up compassion in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that Yahweh, their God, is gracious and merciful and will not turn away his face from the Israelites if the Israelites return to Yahweh. When someone is gracious to us or shows grace to us, that person does something good for us or gives us something good that we do not deserve.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **gracious** or **grace**. Look up grace in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

God is merciful. This means God is full of mercy; God wants to show mercy to people. The word mercy means goodness, kindness, or compassion. The meaning of mercy can be similar to the meaning of the word grace. Grace means that we receive something that we do not deserve. Grace and mercy go together. It is because of God's mercy that God does not punish us, and then it is because of God's grace that God also gives us good things.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **merciful** or **mercy**. Look up mercy in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

God's hand, or power, was on the people in Judah to give them one **heart** to follow the **word**, or message, of Yahweh**. You will remember that in this culture, the people believed that the heart was the center of emotion and decision-making. The word of Yahweh is the message or instruction from Yahweh. Use the same words or phrases for heart and "word of Yahweh" as you have used previously, and refer to heart and word in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.